



The State of Gender Equality in Rwanda

Ensuring Gender Equality Gains from Sustainable Transformation

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Executive Summary

This report on the status of gender equality in Rwanda traces the levels parity that exists in different circumstances as guided by the National Strategy for Transformation (NST1) pillars: economic, social and governance transformation. It highlights the fundamental issues, challenges and opportunities facing the men and women as they shape their livelihood strategies in Rwanda while also proposing programmatic interventions that can be instrumental in informing interventions to reduce the gender equality gaps.

The findings of this report are based on an analyses of various outcome indicators under the aforementioned three pillars with a focus on access to education, food, health, financial services and general participation in Rwanda's decision making platform in the different arms including the executive, judiciary, and legislature, both ant national and local levels. The analysis also focuses on the impact of Covid-19 on critical aspects of employment, income generation and gender based violence. These areas, among others, were previously reflected in the first edition of the status of gender inequality in Rwanda.

Motivated by the dynamics and trends in gender accountability within national, regional and global platforms, and its role in supporting socio-economic transformation, the Gender Monitoring office (GMO) is a strategic institution mandated with driving gender inclusive transformations at all levels. This is to be achieved through coordinated specific interventions which are grounded on Rwanda's local social, economic, institutional and political context and GMO's mission and core values vision as fundamental ingredients to reduce the gender inequality patterns across different sectors. It ttherefore, become imperative to conduct a situation analysis of the gender inequality status as a gateway to map the persistent issues, gaps and opportunities in the economic, social and governance sub-systems. The insights from this analysis will help decision makers to reflect on the possible transformation processes as guided by the proposed key programmatic intervention areas in response to the gaps and opportunities that have been identified. Critically, the efforts will also help to trace and reshape the gender resilience to various shocks using the case of Covid-19 which affected multiple functions in critical sectors including education, health and agriculture, while offering new opportunities in the utilisation of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) tools in supporting coping, adaptation and possible resilience.

The participatory and inclusive process that yielded the results presented in this report was informed by data from three complementary approaches including the desk review mainly building on the 2019 report, thematic technical deliberative forums (TDFs): Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and Key Informants Interviews (KIIs). The desk research provided an extensive review of existing research documents including national surveys, sector specific reports or scholarly published studies and any documents capturing gender equality, equity, and women empowerment efforts in Rwanda. The FGDs and KIIs offered key insights and reflections from community members and officials in the districts on fundamental issues raised from the desk research as a way of clarifying the issues in situ. Finally, the TDFs were used to confirm and validate preliminary findings from the literature and key consultations while capturing and documenting the milestones, and gaps while supporting the formulation of the proposed future policy and programmatic actions towards gender equality, equity, and women empowerment in Rwanda.

The results from this review show that Rwanda has made huge strides in preventing gender-based discrimination while promoting equality between women and men. The main issues identified in the economic transformation pillar included differentials in: access to productive resources in agriculture, labour market participation, business ownership and participation, digital divide, and access to financial resources. The social pillar isolated inequalities in access to education especially in Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) and students with disabilities. Overall, there is a commendable progress in gender parity in access to education at primary and secondary schools, while huge gaps still

exist in higher education. Though data gaps were identified, access to health and social protection programs is relatively balanced for men and women. Findings from the transformation pillar indicate mixed results in participation of women in the legislature, with significant gains at the local levels while the national level shows relatively static conditions since 2019. Huge gaps are reported for women participation in the media. Household level conflicts also show gains in cases of gender based domestic violence and teenage pregnancies, thus showing the effectiveness of existing interventions.

Apart from the above core focal areas for addressing gender inequality, the incidences of shocks and its implication of the gender gaps was also identified. It is reiterated in this report how the Covid-19 pandemic had mixed impacts on women's employment, businesses, income, and prevalence of gender-based violence in Rwanda. These findings point towards programmatic intervention areas to address these shocks related issues that revolve around promoting women in businesses, including Small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) and the informal sector which employ a significant proportion of women. This improves their economic empowerment while aggregately enhancing their opportunities for participation in private sector activities.

The study proposes actions to address the gender inequality gaps and these are clustered under four areas: policy and strategic actions, actions linked to planning and budgeting of gender responsive investments, and actions to improve gender monitoring, learning, and evaluation; and specific sector level recommendations where the gaps persist across the three pillars of the NST1. Specific pathways include enhancing women empowerment at all levels of decision making, improving women's access to productive resources, health facilities and services, formal employment in strategic economic sectors and enhancing access of girls to quality education. It is also critical to aggressively collect data on gender based violence hotspot in Rwanda and design an early warning and response system that is supported by local level institutions in the villages and sectors.

It is hugely anticipated that issues, gaps and opportunities identified in this report and the proposed programmatic intervention areas will support the reduction of gender inequality across multiple sectors in Rwanda. To achieve this, GMO needs to foster collaborations with key stakeholders and partners in Rwanda, the region and globally. This status review is a concrete reflection point in reshaping gender inclusive strategies as the country moves towards achieving the goals of Vision 2050, where no one is to be left behind.

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List of Acronyms and Abbreviations

AU	African Union
BDfA	Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action
CGSR	Country Gender Status Report
CIP	Crop Intensification Program
CSOs	Civil Society Organizations
DHSs	Demographic and Health Surveys
DPs	Development Partners
EAC	East African Community
EICVs	Integrated Household Living Conditions Surveys
ERF	Economic Recovery Fund
FBOs	Faith Based Organizations
FGDs	Focus Group Discussions
GEWE	Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment
GMO	Gender Monitoring Office
GoR	Government of Rwanda
HCI	Human Capital Index
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
KIIs	Key Informants Interviews
M&E	Monitoring and Evaluation
MFIs	Micro-Finance Institutions
MIGEPROF	Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion
MINECOFIN	Ministry of Finance and Economic Planning
MINEDUC	Ministry of Education
MINICOM	Ministry of Trade and Industry
MoH	Ministry of Health
NGOs	Non-Government Organizations
NISR	National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda
NST	National Strategic for Transformation
NWC	National Women's Council

RDB	Rwanda Development Board
RGB	Rwanda Governance Board
RIB	Rwanda Investigation Bureau
RNP	Rwanda National Police
RWAMREC	Rwanda Men's Resource Centre
RWN	Rwanda Women's Network
SDGs	Global Sustainable Development Goals
TDFs	Thematic Deliberative Forums
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNESCO	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization
USAID	United States Agency for International Development

1. General Introduction

1.1. Background

In the past two decades, the Government of Rwanda (GoR) has implemented several policies and programmes to promote gender equality. This ensured that human rights and fundamentals of freedom are realized on equal terms between women and men. These efforts have explicitly expressed both the will and commitment to promote accountability for gender equality, equity, and women empowerment in all sectors and at all levels. This is observed, among others, through several direct and indirect interventions related to progressively mainstreaming gender and women empowerment across the various strategic economic sectors such as agriculture and manufacturing. In as much as several definitions of gender are emerging in recent literature, the founding principles of the definition which gravitate around the concept being a social construct, which invariably differs from society to society and can change over time are accounted for in this report.

The commitment of Rwanda to gender equality and empowerment of women and girls is aligned with other global and regional development agendas and strategies such as the Global Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs -2030), African Union (AU) Agenda (2063), East African Community (EAC) vision 2050, African Union Strategy for Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment [GEWE] (2018-2028), and African Union Gender Policy (2009). For instance, the SDG-5 specifically provides for “*gender equality and empower women and girls*”. In the same line, in its aspiration six, the African Agenda 2063 aims to strengthen the role of African women through ensuring gender equality and parity in all spheres of life (political, economic and social). Therefore, Rwanda's achievements on gender equality and empowerment of women and girls simultaneously respond to goals of national transformation and in meeting global and regional commitments in this particular area.

The GoR has adopted numerous regional and international treaties, conventions and agreements that accommodate and promote gender equality. From the policy perspective, interventions towards gender equality and empowerment of women draws from the national policy and associated policy frameworks. These comprise among them, the Vision 2050, the National Strategy for National Transformation (NST1), the National Gender Policy (2021), Gender Equality Strategy: UNDP Rwanda (2019-2022) and the Sector Strategic Plans (SSPs). The Vision 2050 provides a long-term strategic orientation on specific consideration of women and youth in the transformation of the economy and modernizing lives of all Rwandans as Rwanda transitions into becoming a Middle-Income Country by 2035. In addition, the NST-1 which is a 7-year government programme translate this vision by strengthening and promoting gender equality using mainstreaming avenues for gender across sector strategies, district strategies, and national level investment plans.

From the legal perspective, goals of gender equality and empowerment are enshrined by a progressive and dynamic legal reform process. The National Constitution revised in 2015 in addition to other several laws have been enacted to ensure gender equality and equal representation of men and women in decision making positions. For instance, law No. 59/2008 on the Prevention and Punishment of Gender-Based Violence

(GBV) prevents and punishes Gender Based Violence Crimes in all of its forms; law No 10/20/2013/OL of 11/07/2013 governing land in Rwanda, guarantees equal rights for men and women on land access, ownership and utilization; the law N°27/2016 of 08/07/2016 governing matrimonial regimes, donations and successions, provides for women's equal inheritance rights with men); and the law No.66/2018 of 30/08/2018 regulating labour in Rwanda, provides for equal opportunities and pay for women and men; rights to full salary to a female employee who gives birth during 3 months of maternity leave and the breastfeeding period; working conditions for a pregnant or breastfeeding woman and prohibits sexual harassment in the workplace. These remedial legal provisions are designed to support the various pathways for enhancing opportunities for all while reflecting on possibilities of conflicts during the process.

Furthermore, Rwanda has established relevant institutional mechanisms both at central and decentralized entities to ensure effective coordination of interventions meant to promote gender mainstreaming, gender accountability, policy formulation, and empowerment of women (GMO, 2021). Gender has been enshrined in Rwanda's constitution and this has been a key driving factor in strengthening empowerment of women to participate in decision making position and seizing potential economic opportunities. Further, gender equality and women's empowerment are instituted by the creation of the Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion, Gender Monitoring Office (GMO), National Women's Council (NWC) which has representatives up to the decentralized levels, and other institutions and platforms in the gender machinery. The gender machinery, in turn, has also played a crucial role in ensuring effective mainstreaming of the gender components across sectors.

Monitoring and documenting the state of gender equality in Rwanda is an important exercise initiated since 2018 by GMO in collaboration with its partners and stakeholders in order to understand the progress and gaps, identify factors underpinning the progress or persistent gaps, advise the government, civil society organizations (CSOs), and development partners (DPs) on policy planning and programme design, and to serve as a hub of gender related information. The state of gender equality is therefore explored by assessing the progress of key selected indicators in the various sub-sectors under the three pillars of the prevailing government's NST-1: economic transformation, social transformation, and transformative governance. More specifically, the objectives of this Country Gender Status Report (CGSR) are to:

- Document and showcase Rwanda's progress and achievements on GEWE's four strategic pillars and outcome areas across different sectors,
- Examine the socio-cultural, economic, political, and legal barriers that hinder the effective implementation of GEWE related interventions and commitments as well as the available opportunities to accelerate efforts to address the observed gender gaps.
- Advise the government, CSOs, and DPs on policy and programmatic actions that would inform the planning of gender related interventions.
- Serve as a hub of gender related information for subsequent formulation of national policies, sector strategies, and gender responsive programmes towards sustainable transformation in Rwanda.

1.2. Scope of the report

This report is the second of its nature after the first one published in 2019 covering the period 2000-2018. It builds on the previous state of gender equality to document the progress made and persistent gender

related gaps against the baseline status in 2018 across the three NST-1's pillars: economic transformation, social transformation, and transformational governance. The report describes and discusses equality between men or boys and women or girls while documenting driving factors of the observed progress, persistent challenges, and recommendations for policy and programmatic actions in the future. The analysis of this state of gender equality covers the period 2019 to 2022/23.

2. Methodological process

2.1. Analytical framework

This report documents the country's state of gender equality, equity, and women economic empowerment. The performance on key indicators is compared with the status of 2019 previously observed in the first generation of the CGSR. Data and information used were gathered through a content and descriptive analysis of relevant resource materials complemented by insights obtained from consultative approach through Focus Group Discussions (FGDs and consultations with key informants. A set of agreed indicators to guide this status report were identified and proposed before the analysis under the three NST-1's pillars: economic transformation, social transformation and transformative governance. Specifically, three stages characterize this methodological process:

Stage 1: The analysis started with an assessment of the existing report on the state of gender equality in Rwanda published in 2019. The purpose was to identify potential gaps and to monitor the progress made in the context of new dynamics such as the situation during and post the Covid-19 pandemic and global shocks and disruptions in food supply triggered by the War in Ukraine.

Stage 2: At the second stage, previous and recent values of selected indicators were documented and reported, discussed, and interpreted in terms of the gaps or progress made as well as their respective implications from the gender lens across the three NST-1 pillars.

Stage 3: Building on the reflections made in stages 1 and 2, the study has proposed key recommendations in the form of policy, strategic, and programmatic actions to improve areas that have been identified as gaps and to strengthen areas of successes observed during the analysis.

2.2. Data collection techniques

During the data collection process, three main techniques were considered:

- (1) **Desk research:** An extensive literature review of existing research documents was conducted. These include national surveys, sector specific reports or studies as well as any other relevant document, mainly those dealing with gender equality, equity, and women's empowerment in Rwanda. These were complemented by scholarly published papers, with focus to those on Rwanda, while experiences from other countries provided potential lessons and traps that could be configured to suit the Rwandan contexts.
- (2) **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and Key Informants Interviews (KIIs):** Insights from community members and officials from the districts on specific issues identified from the literature review and secondary data have added value in the discussion of the observed status on gender equality, equity, and women's economic empowerment. These people are critical since they live the experiences and also directly engage with affected individuals such as victims of Gender Based Violence (GBV).

- (3) ***Thematic Deliberative Forums (TDFs)***: Technical Deliberative Forums (TDFs) were organized in a form of plenary and small group discussions around the three thematic pillars. The discussions were primarily based on preliminary findings from the literature and key consultations through FGDs and KIIs. The advantage of this technique is twofold: First, this allows researchers to confirm some of the information or validate some of the statistics and assumptions raised during the secondary data analysis. Secondly, the methodological process of this country's gender status report was participatory and inclusive of key stakeholders, including government agencies, CSOs, DPs, faith-based organizations, and the academia. Their insights were instrumental to document both the progress, the gaps, and in contributing to the proposed future policy and programmatic actions shaped to achieve higher levels of gender equality, equity, and empowerment of women in Rwanda.

3. The State of Gender Equality

As already indicated, the presentation of the state of gender equality in Rwanda is done per identified sector or economic activity under each of the three NST-1's pillars: economic transformation, social transformation, and transformational governance. This ensures adequate coverage of the fundamental issues affecting women and men in various activities of day to day life.

3.1. Gender equality in Economic Transformation

Economic transformation is reiterated in the national policy and development frameworks as a core pillar of the aggregate national transformation. Ensuring gender equality and equity is part of efforts for inclusive socioeconomic transformation. For this pillar, the focus is the assessment of the state of gender equality in the following areas: agriculture, water and electricity, employment, financial inclusion, Information, Communication, and Technology (ICT), and private sector and business development.

3.1.1. Agriculture

Agriculture remains a strategic sector for Rwanda. The analysis of gender equality status in agriculture focuses mainly on the access to productive resources by both men and women: agricultural inputs (e.g., seeds, organic, and inorganic fertilizers), ownership of productive assets (i.e., land and livestock), agricultural loans, extension services, and adoption of soil and water management measures.

Access to agricultural inputs

Findings reveal that access to improved seeds by women headed households has increased by about 10% from 26.9% to 36.4% against a 14.2% change recorded for men headed households during the period from 2018 to 2021/22. In addition, access to organic and inorganic fertilizers by women has also increased from 75.2% to 79.3%, with a positive change of 4.1% for women and 4.6% for men. While access and use of improved seeds and inorganic fertilizers is generally limited for both men and women, the situation is more pronounced for female farmers where currently the gender gap ranges from 6.2% for use of organic fertilizers, 11.5% for chemical fertilizers and 12.4% for improved seeds (see Table 1).

Table 1: Access to agricultural inputs

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Households (HHs) (female and male headed) having purchased improved seeds for agricultural production	33.6	26.9	47.8	36.4
HHs (female and male headed) having purchased organic fertilizers for agricultural production	80.9	75.2	85.5	79.3
HHs (female and male headed) having purchased chemical fertilizers for agricultural production	34.9	23	42.3	30.8

Source: NISR (Agriculture Household Survey (AHS) 2017, 2020)

The gender parity gap observed in access to agricultural inputs is partly explained by limited purchasing power coupled with high cost of inputs and longer distances to the markets which hinder access of required

quantities of agricultural inputs, among others. In addition, access to these inputs is mainly determined by the subsidy programme which targets mainly cash crops under the Crop Intensification Program (CIP) (e.g., maize, Irish potato, wheat, rice, tea, and coffee); these commercial crops tend to be more cultivated and controlled by men while women concentrate on the traditional subsistence crops such as sorghum and millets. Further, more access to inputs is likely to happen for farmers who are organized in cooperatives or through registration in *Nkunganire programme*, where currently women account for 45% of cooperative membership as compared to 55% of their men counterparts¹. Consequently, limited access to productive inputs by women would translate into the gender gap in agricultural productivity presently estimated at 11.7% (Rodgers, & Akram-Lodhi, 2019) and which further sustain the lower agricultural income status.

Access to agricultural loans

The number of loans by women has significantly reduced by 78.5% against 57.4% for men farmers during the period under review (see Figure 1). Even though the trend has reduced for both men and women, the gender parity gap remains too high and estimated at 77%. This gender gap is mainly explained by the fact that women face significant family burdens related to child care, health, and other basic family needs. This situation often leads them to exhibit greater risk aversion and therefore be inclined to use credit as a development tool (Musabanganji *et al.*, 2015). In addition, the use of financial products by women is influenced by social norms such as the manipulation by spouses and other family members. These conditions make it difficult for the women to independently finance their farming activities as well as other businesses (AFR, 2023).

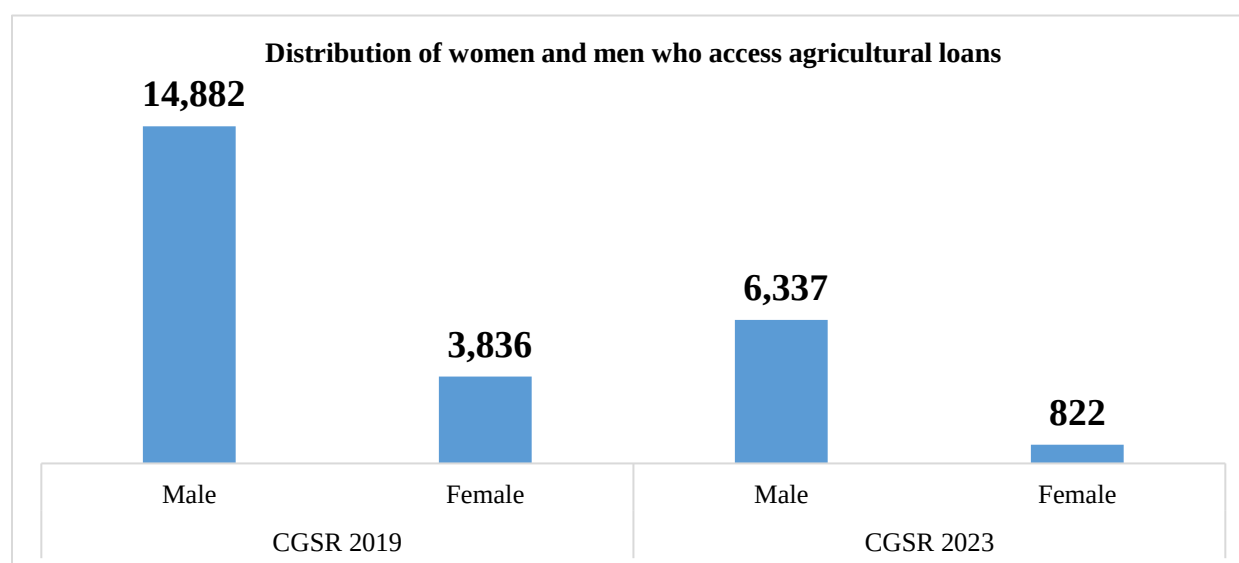


Figure 1: Access to agricultural loans

Source: Annual BNR Report (2021).

Apart from structural challenges and social norms, this status has been further distorted by negative effects of the Covid-19 pandemic that constrained the access and repayment capacity of small-scale farmers of the agricultural loans initially contracted with providers of financial services. Consequently, women continue

¹ RCA (March, 2023).

to be financially excluded, thus calling for more innovative solutions to support prospects for their financial inclusion through for example effective training in financial literacy. The existing conditions comprise leveraging on financial schemes for agricultural transformation. This therefore reinforce the need for ‘*out of the box*’ gender sensitive agricultural schemes and products (such as agricultural insurance and de-risking) to be provided by formal financial institutions as a gateway to enhance capacity of men and women and to develop bankable and context specific agriculture based projects.

Access to agricultural extension services

Extension services are provided mainly by the government agencies coordinated by the Rwanda Agriculture Board (RAB). The institution established several extension mechanisms including farmer field facilitators through *Twigire Muhinzi* scheme, a community participatory approach which combines Farmer Field Schools (FFS) and field-based Farmer Promoters (FP). Agricultural extension services are designed to build farmers’ abilities to adopt, use, and maintain good agricultural practices for increasing their agricultural productivity and scale of production. The trend in access to other areas of agriculture extension services is generally positive for both men and women in spite of the Covid-19 pandemic induced challenges of delivering using traditional methods. Agricultural households with access to extension services such as post-harvest handling and storage, erosion control measures and horticulture skills continue to increase in the last five years (see Table 2).

Table 2: Access to extension services and distribution of extension agents

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Female and male headed agricultural HHs who received crop production extension services				
Agriculture practices	75.9	78.5	43.7	56.3
Post-harvest handling and storage	7.9	4.9	45.7	54.3
Erosion control measures	13.4	12.3	44.9	55.1
Horticulture skills	4	3.7	42.9	57.1
Animal production and nutrition	83.9	83.7	47.2	52.8
Integrated pest management			45.6	54.4
Nutrition and food security			42.2	57.8
Smart Nkunganire System (SNS)			48.0	52.0
Adoption of soil and water management measures				
Irrigation	11.5	6.4	16.3	10.2
Agroforestry trees	-	-	48.8	39.6
Erosion control measures	67.1	61.8	85.2	80.0

Source: NISR (Agriculture Household Survey (AHS) 2017, 2020)

The GoR, through agricultural extension agencies, has instituted more efforts which have progressively gathered momentum in providing extension services to farmers using different channels and approaches. These include local radio networks and community mobilization at the start of the season to ensure timely and effective application of best agricultural practices. As result, households using agricultural practices such as irrigation and erosion control measures have increased regardless the negative effects of Covid-19 pandemic. However, of concern is the gender disparity which is still high (ranging from 5% to 9%) in terms of adopting agriculture productive infrastructure such as irrigation, agroforestry, and erosion control measures.

Based on the results in Table 3, it is also observed that the number of men farmer field school facilitators has increased by 8.8% while it has reduced by the same level for women from 34.3% to 25.5% in the reference period. Similarly, the number of women farmers trained through Farmer Field Schools (FFSs) has slightly declined for women from 52% to 50%. Yet, a high gender disparity among the farmer promoters is noted where men are represented at 75.3% compared to 24.7% of women.

Table 3: Number of farmer field school (FFS) master trainers, facilitators and trained farmers

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Farmer field school master trainers	25	19	-	-
Farmer field school facilitators	1,671	876	1,576	542
Trained farmers	46,491	50,365	309,381	319,999
Farmer promoters	-	-	10,623	3,490

Source: RAB - Administrative data (2021)

Overall, the approaches being used have increased the provision of extension services through tailor made training and improvements in the quality of extension service delivery, while adopting Information and Communication Technology (ICT) alternatives. In as much as women are dominant in accessing training as compared to men, they are less represented among the farmer trainers through the above mentioned extension support scheme. Therefore, there is need to increase women's participation in extension services beyond being recipient farmers but also to be more visible as farmer facilitators and promoters. This gender gap is mainly explained by gender related stereotypes and cultural norms that affect women's confidence to attend extension master classes and prohibiting unmonitored interaction of non-related men and women during meetings. Consequently, this limits the opportunities for women to have access to updated farming related information and extract value from decent farming practices which have the potential to improve their livelihood conditions.

Land ownership

Land is the main primary asset for production and investment. However, this resource is increasingly becoming scarce due to progressively high population density and competitive requirements for agriculture and other economic activities. Therefore, access to land, land ownership, and use by both women and men are important considerations in assessing gender equality and empowerment of women in Rwanda. Clearly, there is a general decline in land ownership across different categories of owners during the two reference periods of 2017 and 2023 (see Figure 2). Of major concern is the unclassified land (others) which has hugely increased from 2% to 21%. However, it is difficult to identify for now other causal factors beyond the demographic conditions and land use management in explaining the observed status of land ownership by women. Possible explanation is the unclassified land uses for transacted plot parcels where the transactions have increased from 255,335 plot parcels in 2017 to 444 197 plot parcels in 2021.

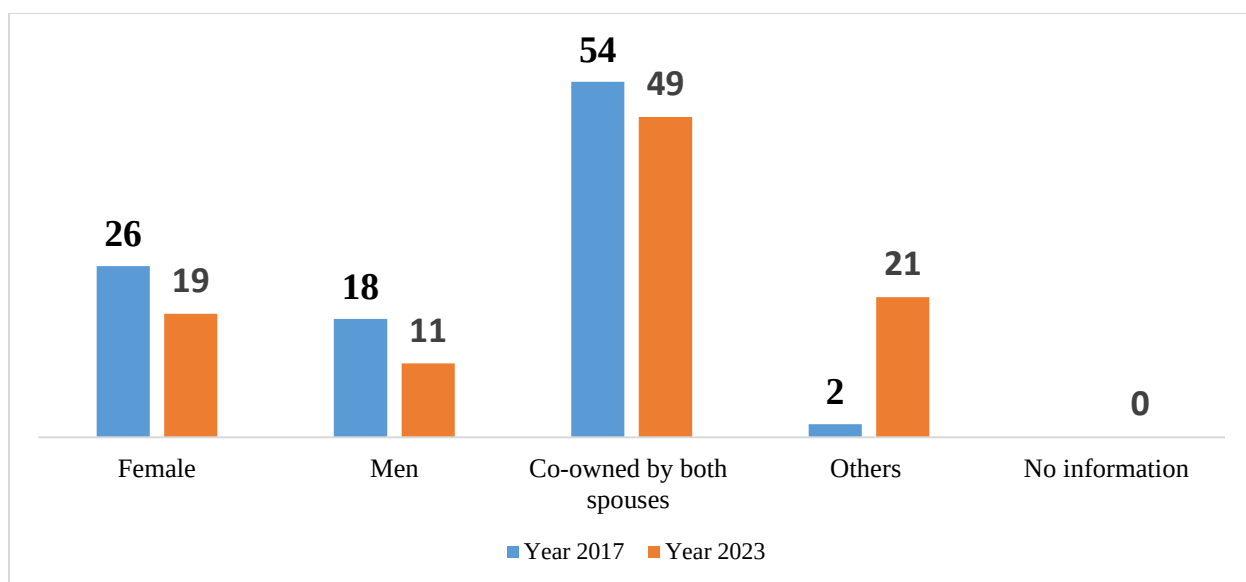


Figure 2: Land ownership (2017-2023)

Source: Rwanda Land Dashboard [Accessed 24th June, 2023].

Specific to agricultural land, the levels of land ownership have declined for both men and women by 5.4% and 5.5% respectively when considering the period from 2019 to 2023 as shown in Table 4 below. Further, there is no significant change observed in using land as collateral for access to credit, and this would translate into the recurrently observed limited access to financial loans for capital investment by both men and women in agriculture. It is further revealed how women rent out their agricultural land with a 2.9% differential value as compared to the status of their counterpart male headed households.

Table 4: Land ownership in agriculture

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
HHs (female and male headed) owning agricultural land	92.9	93.8	87.4	88.3
HHs (female and male headed) renting agricultural land	58.3	40.6	53.2	39.9
HHs (female and male headed) renting out agricultural land	9.7	12.6	9.7	12.6
Average total area (in Ha) cultivated per HHs (female and male headed) per season	0.6	0.5	0.6	0.5
HHs (female and male headed) using land as collateral	41.6	39.9	41.6	39.9
Number of parcels owned by (men and women)	1,283,253	2,194,773	1,272,133	2,158,221

Source: NISR: National Gender Statistics, 2021; EICV 4 (ENR Thematic Report) and EICV5 (Gender Thematic Report)

Overall, results in Table 4 show how land remains a scarce resource, with women being the most affected as their per capita cultivated area averages 0.5 ha against 0.6 ha for men. Similarly, it is well supported how use of land as a collateral to access loans has not changed over the reference period. Therefore, the decline in land ownership for both men and women coupled with the specific women's inability to renting agricultural land, reflect a diminishing productive capacity of women. This status in turn negatively affects their economic empowerment prospects, given the reliability of most households on agriculture for food

and income. Subsequently, in the short run, efforts are needed to support women to place them on a trajectory that allows them to efficiently utilize the limited available land through agricultural modernization while basing on the anticipated boom in women's active involvement and employment in the industry and services sectors in the long run.

Livestock ownership

Table 5 shows that, the ownership of livestock has declined between 2017 and 2021. However, male headed households own more cattle than women headed households with a 11.9% difference recorded using the current estimate. Women are only dominantly raising goats with a 5.3% difference as compared to male headed households. Thus, ownership of small stock remains scarce with various implication such as limited scope for livestock to become a reliable source of food and income. High levels of cattle ownership is also observed in the recent national census, as it accounts for 33.4% of total agricultural households compared to households raising small livestock like goat, pig, hen and sheep (with 23.2%, 17.9%, 14.3% and 5.6% of total households respectively).

Table 5: Livestock ownership

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
HHs (female and male headed) raising different types of livestock				
Cattle	64.6	51.0	56.6	44.7
Goats	51.2	60.2	36.2	41.5
Sheep	17.9	18.6	10.4	8.5
Pigs	31.5	28.0	35.9	27.7
Rabbits	15.8	12.9	9.2	7.0
Hen	36.2	26.7	34.3	23.2
Other poultry	7.8	8.0	1.7	0.8

Source: NISR (Agriculture Household Survey (AHS) 2017, 2020),

3.1.2. Employment, Entrepreneurship, and Business Development

This sub-section analyses the differentials in gender equality terms of men and women's participation in labour force, positions occupied by women and men in the labour market, employment of women and men by economic activity, unpaid care work, and women's participation in the private sector and business development.

Labour Force Participation

Access to employment and especially decent and productive jobs by women in various sectors is critical for their economic empowerment. Women remain less represented in the labour force at 48.8% in 2021/22 compared to 64.1% for men, with an estimate of 15.3% of the gender parity gap (see Figure 3). However, the change of this representation over the last five years falls within the same range as the 2.6% recorded for women's participation and the 2.2% for men's participation in the labour force.

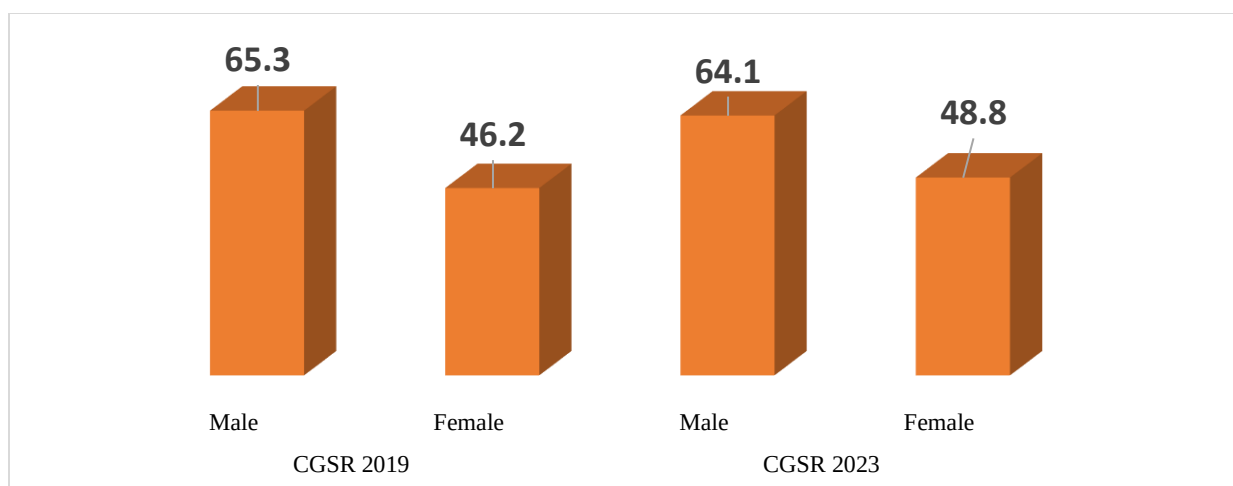


Figure 3: Labor force participation rate (%)

Source: NISR, Labor Force Survey (LFS) 2017 and 2023

Looking at the sector level, agriculture sector employs a large share of both male and female population (39.8% and 55.6% respectively), followed by the services and industry sectors (see Table 6). Expectedly, women remain more represented in market-oriented agriculture and consistently less represented in industries while their representation in serves has reduced by 5.2% in the last five years from 40.1% to 34.9%.

Table 6: Employment in Agriculture, Industry and Services

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Market oriented agriculture	34.1	51.4	39.8	55.6
Industry	23.0	8.5	23.4	9.5
Services	42.8	40.1	36.7	34.9

Source: NISR, Labour Force Survey, 2017 and 2023

In as much as agriculture remains the main source of employment or activity by both men and women in rural areas of Rwanda, it is still observed that there are differences in the involvement of women and men in specific agricultural related activities. Data from consultations shows that women tend to concentrate on activities such as weeding, planting and taking care of small livestock while the field preparation and harvesting are mainly done by men. Of note is that, this is more pronounced for commercial crops such as coffee and potato. This trend has not yet significantly changed during the review period, thus showing the relatively static nature of gender attributes in this area of decision making for agriculture functions. It was also reported that in terms of assets ownership positive changes have been observed over the review period. However, in the past, the valuable assets included banana plantation, coffee plantation, cows, and land which used to be considered as belonging solely to men with no ownership arrangements for women. The advent of legal reforms has changed the landscape resulting in migration towards equal ownership of these assets especially for legally married men and women. Of concern is that, there still remains some notable gender gaps especially when it comes to the decision in the use or allocation of these assets for productive gains.

Results in Table 7 below show that, the unemployment rate among men and women has slightly increased for both men (4.4%) and women (6.6%). This finds explanation mainly from the closure or downscaling operations by businesses which employ the majority of men and women in terms of short-term jobs during the period of Covid-19 pandemic. It is also evident how the unemployment rate among the youth has increased during the review period. Furthermore, the number of employed women and men in informal sector has increased in the 2021/22 period when compared the 2017/18 period, but has however decreased in the formal sector. The number of employees per sector for both men and women has increased when comparing the two periods of 2017/18 and 2021/22. It is also encouraging to note the increment of the average monthly income estimated at 6,114 Frw for men and 7,147 Frw for women. However, this is still worrying given the shifts in macro-economic fundamentals such as the Consumer Price Index (CPI), which is the main gauge of inflation that increased by 14.1% year on year in May 2023 down from 17.8% in April 2023. These conditions expose both men and women who are employed to the shocks of declining real purchasing power and thus compromising their livelihoods and ability to save.

Table 7: Distribution of population (female and male) employed by sector of employment

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Labor force participation rate (%)	65.3	46.2	64.1	48.8
Number of employed populations in informal sector	1,265,386	1,089,484	1,931,902	1,480,968
Number of employed populations in formal sector	311,098	171,535	273,792	163,927
Employment to population ratio (%)	55.2	37.9	52.7	37.3
Underemployment rate (%)	25.2	32.0	29.6	34.4
Unemployment rate (%)	13.5	17.1	17.9	23.7
Youth unemployment rate (16 – 30 years)	16.0	21.9	22.3	29.4
Positions occupied by women and men in labor market				
Managerial positions	65.9	34.1	73.9	26.1
Chief Executive, Senior Officers & Legislators	66.5	33.5	80.7	19.3
Administrative and Commercial Managers	65.5	34.5	67.5	32.6
Employed men and women by economic activity				
Agriculture, fishing and forestry	45.4	54.6	47.5	52.5
Mining and quarrying	94.2	5.8	79.6	20.4
Manufacturing	55.7	44.3	52.6	47.4
Construction	85.4	14.6	86.6	13.4
Wholesale, retail trade, repair of motor vehicles, motorcycles	48.7	51.3	43.2	56.8
Transportation and storage	97.0	3.0	96.0	4.0
Accommodation and food service activities	53.0	47.0	59.6	40.4
Information and communication	74.5	25.5	72.2	27.8
Financial and Insurance activities	50.1	49.9	54.8	45.2
Professional, scientific and technical activities	68.9	31.1	72.6	27.4
Public administration and defense	74.2	25.8	74.3	25.7
Education	54.3	45.7	50.2	49.8
Human health and social work activities	46.1	53.9	43.1	56.9
Average monthly income earned by male and female employees aged 16+yrs at main job	69,301	39,979	75,415	47,126

Source: NISR, Rwanda Labor Force Survey (RLFS Annual Report 2018 and 2022)

An analysis of the positions occupied by men and women in employing institutions and organizations, generally men occupy more positions than women in all categories of institutions: public, private, cooperatives, NGOs (both local and international), as well as in public private partnerships (see Table 8).

Table 8: Number of employees by categories of institutions and sex

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Public	46,860	31,308	55,903	37,973
Private	259,748	149,755	285,446	167,387
Public Private Partnership	31,440	25,276	27,979	24,119
Cooperative	29,311	18,736	41,743	32,706
NGO (Local)	13,570	6,799	16,937	12,150
NGO (International)	2,405	1,529	2,218	1,579

Source: NISR: Establishment Census Reports (2017 and 2020)

In view of the above differences observed between categories of positions occupied by men and women as well as the types of employment for women and men, partial explanation for some positions and category of jobs can be bound by them being stereotypically considered by the society to be more appropriate for males and cultural barriers that reduce opportunities for women who intent to hold senior positions or more paying jobs, among others. This results in the congestion of women in the more informal jobs with consequent lower remuneration, lack of economic stability and less legal protection. But field level consultations have painted a picture of an increasing trend where some of the activities previously done by women are being done by men and vice-versa. It is also increasingly being observed where cases of women and girls are now involved in hair cutting, construction, installation of electricity, transport, and serve in the army and police, all jobs which were previously considered to be solely areas reserved for men. This shift is critical both from the angle of generating decent income but also addressing multiple issues linked to unemployment, underemployment, and unpaid care work as addressed in the next section. Going forward, efforts are needed to strategically facilitate women's access to formal employment and decent job opportunities, as long as they have the required qualifications.

Unpaid care work

A reflection on the ***unpaid care work***, results show that the mean hours spent per week on domestic activities is overall higher for women than men as per aprior expectations. It is only when men have to search for fodder to feed the livestock especially during the lean summer seasons that they spend more time than women. The travel to market, cooking at home, child care, and taking care of elderly people take a huge share of the unpaid care work done by women as compared to their men counterparts. Interestingly, there is no significant difference between men and women when it comes to time allocated for water fetching and collecting firewood for cooking (see Table 9). This would imply, among others, an important progress and shift made in division of labour between men or boys and women or girls as result of improved mindsets that have been transformed by the various interventions implemented in this regard. Also, comparing the two periods, there is an insignificant change in the unpaid care work conditions. This implies that, despite the performance and insignificant inequality observed, challenges linked to unpaid care work will still restrain the progress made in gender aligned productivity. Continued interventions in this regard

will be needed to accelerate the observed pace and impetus for uptake of development programmes and ultimate increased differential contribution of women into the national transformation.

Table 9: Average number of hours spent per week on own use production activities (domestic duties) by type and sex for population 16 years and above

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Looking after children and elderly	3.9	8.8	3.8	7.9
Collect firewood	3.9	4.7	4.1	4.4
Searching fodder or grazing	10.0	7.3	8.9	6.6
Water fetching	4.0	4.3	3.8	3.8
Cooking and shopping	5.5	12.5	5.8	11.6

Source: NISR, Rwanda Labor Force Survey (RLFS Annual Report 2018 and 2022)

It is interesting to note that, opinions from field level consultations support a positive change in mindset especially for men when it comes to unpaid care work. Respondents mentioned that due to involvement of women in paid activities (sometime far from their respective families), men and boys are taking a share of responsibilities in performing some of the unpaid care work such as the laundry, preparation of food, and child care. Consequently, there is a remarkable shift where men are no longer seen as the ‘providers’ to the household needs in rural and urban areas as it traditionally used to be. Despite such mindset shift, one still observes gender stereotypes and social norms resulting in some unpaid care work remaining the core responsibilities of women especially in rural areas. These comprise fetching of firewood and water, seed planting, and weeding as already above documented. In urban areas, women are still seen as being responsible for ironing, food preparation, and the laundry. Similarly, in rural areas roles of cutting trees and looking after the livestock remains preliminary under men’s responsibility. These complex matrices present gender mainstreaming challenges especially in contexts where the responsibilities are crosscutting or overlapping while also being contested according to societal norms.

Clearly, unpaid care work remains a barrier to women’s economic empowerment or financial independence. This is reinforced by gender-based violence (GBV) and disempowerment emanating from skewed and rapidly changing decision-making processes at the household level. These are therefore key challenges towards gender equality and equity in Rwanda. Extra efforts to address this unpaid care work are strongly needed to allow women use efficiently utilize their time. These may include heavily subsidized investment in time saving facilities like the use of energy efficient gas stoves in cooking, solar powered washing machines, and education on integrating gender roles at household level. These specific policy actions and measures are recommended so that these are specifically identified to address such gaps given the variations in the operational contexts. In this regard, in as much as an umbrella recommendation is made, this will need to be adjusted to suit the conditions of the communities within which the implementation is to be done.

3.1.3. Participation of women in the private sector and business development

Participation of women in cross-border trade

Achieving gender equality in the private sector and business development is a commitment made by the government of Rwanda in its National Gender Policy. Women are still less represented in decent areas of the private sector but they are hugely dominant in informal areas such as the cross-border trade as compared

to men. Informal cross-border trade is more vulnerable to potential shocks- which was the case for Covid-19 pandemic and the geo-political dynamics that led to closure or limited trade relationships between Rwanda, Uganda, Burundi, and the DRC. Women are more likely to be affected since they majorly employed in the informal sector including retail trading cross-border trading. For example, both men and women's representation in the informal cross-border trade has declined during the last five years, a decline of 72.6% for men against 76.3% for women as depicted in Figure 4 below. This has some negative implications in terms of reduced income whose main source is the informal cross-border for the traders, reduced purchasing power to procure for household needs since women are the most concerned by the “*food on the plate*”, and increased unemployment for women.

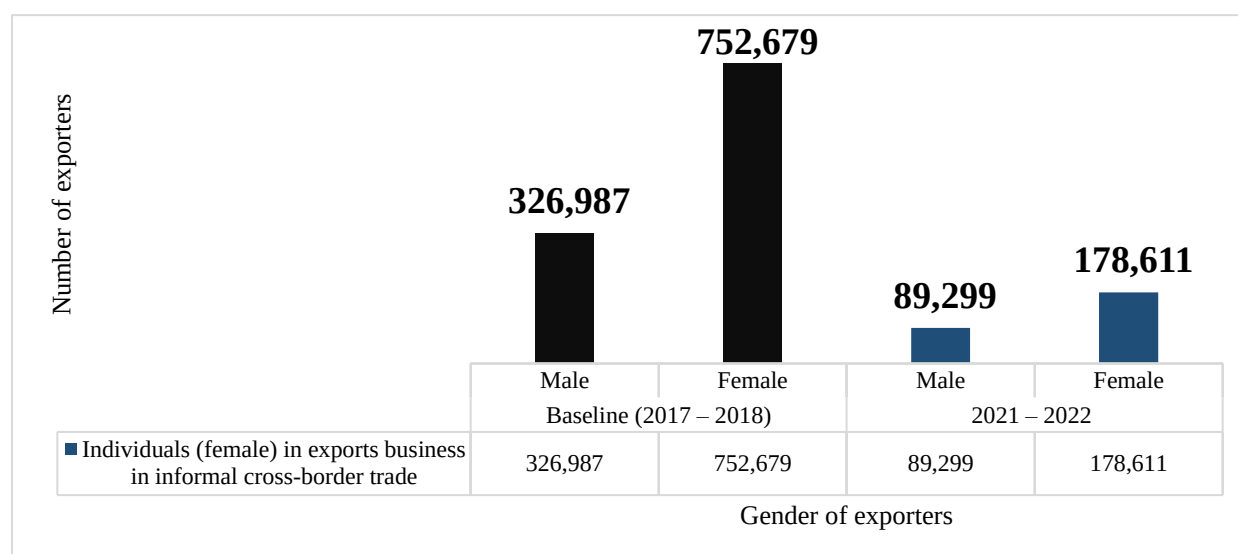


Figure 4: Distribution of men and women in informal cross-border trade

Source: NISR, Statistics Economic Unit, Informal Cross Border Trade reports 2018 and 2021

Establishments and ownership by women and men

The business establishments in Rwanda are grouped in four categories; namely micro, small, medium, and large scale companies. With respect to ownership of small and medium enterprises (SMEs), these are mainly owned by men though the sole proprietorship is concentrated in micro (1-3 employees) and small enterprises (3 to 30 employees) despite the gender disparity across all categories of enterprises. It is further observed that SMEs are constrained by access to adequate capital for investment affecting their ability to operate above the break-even point. In addition, the financial policy environment is not fully customized to accommodate the growth pathways of these SMEs coupled with limited entrepreneur skills especially for rural women, which in turn lead to unprofitable businesses. However, Table 10 shows that, the trend is positive for the three categories over the two periods (2017/18-2021/22), with the exception of large businesses where the representation of men and women declined from 47% to 38% and 16% to 7% respectively. This is encouraging and calls for aggressive support for the smaller businesses as potential hubs for socio-economic transformation in Rwanda. The complexity of formalizing these businesses however presents implementation challenges for robust gender inclusive interventions. However, the GoR and its partners can adopt a more innovative approach and support these businesses as informal.

Table 10: Distribution of sole proprietor establishments (small and medium enterprises) by women and men

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Micro (1-3 employees)	112,242	54,813	121,905	74,242
Small (4-to-30 employees)	4,824	2,005	4,970	2,404
Medium (31-to-100 employees)	141	25	175	46
Large (+ 100 employees)	47	16	38	7

Source : NISR - Establishment Census Report (2017 and 2020).

Looking at the representation in the managerial positions per category of enterprises, women remain less represented when compared to their men counterparts though with patterns showing increased number of enterprises. Table 11 shows that, they account for only 29.3% representation in small enterprises. This status is even more elaborately observed in the medium and large-scale enterprises where women are represented by 21% and 17.8%, respectively. These levels of women's representation are consistent with their levels of ownership of small enterprises. This status has some negative implications such as limited access to off-farm jobs, increased gender productivity gap, and continued reliance on farm income rather than taking up decent opportunities in the managerial level within SMEs.

Table 11: Distribution (in numbers) of Establishments (enterprises) by size and by sex of manager

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Micro (1-3 employees)	114,306	56,740	130,357	79,351
Small (4-to-30 employees)	9,719	3,638	10,093	4,179
Medium (31-to-100 employees)	1,332	366	1,512	403
Large (+ 100 employees)	305	42	283	44

Source : Establishment Census Report (NISR, 2017 and 2020).

An analysis of entrepreneurship for men and women, shows that the dominant economic activities include wholesale and retail trade; repair of motor vehicles; accommodation and food services, and manufacturing businesses (see Table 12). The status shows an increment of enterprise establishments in these selected subsectors over the last five years. Worryingly, women are still less visible, with a representation ranging from 25.9% to 44.1% against 57.7% to 74.1% of men's representation.

Table 12: Distribution (in numbers) of sole proprietor establishments by economic activity and sex of owner

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Agriculture, forestry and fishing business	111	25	83	29
Manufacturing business	7,970	5,172	8,533	6,260
Water supply, sewage, waste management and remediation activity	248	120	362	286
Wholesale and retail trade; repair of motor vehicles	58,705	34,888	73,410	51,291
Accommodation and food service activities	37,864	13,290	29,881	13,242

Source : Establishment Census Report (NISR, 2017 and 2020)

Overall, cognizant of the progress made over the last five years in terms of women's entrepreneurship and business development, they still face various structural challenges making the survival rate of established

business remaining low. Some studies (e.g., Twesige et al., 2020²) show that 50% of the businesses that are started in Rwanda do not exceed five years life, even those which exceed five years, only a fraction remains in operation in the next decade. The study by Kasema (2021)³ also points out that businesses registered by women are the most vulnerable (with a failure rate of 70%) due to their entrepreneur's inability followed by the enterprise incompetence, which are both internally controllable factors and the business environment which does not consider specific gender related challenges. This has negative implications when it comes to establishment ownership and employment of women beyond primary agriculture while taking up opportunities both in the industry and services. More support programmes should help to address identified issues linked to business failure like poor cash flow management, limited capacity of market research before starting their businesses, lack of bankable business plans, and expense and revenue management, among others.

3.1.4. Information and Communication Technology (ICT)

Information Communication, and Technology (ICT) is one of global impact commitments of which Rwanda had committed to bridge the gender digital divide and attain parity in ICT access, usage and innovation by 2020. It is with no doubt that ICT is increasingly becoming the engine for national economic transformation through digitized products and services, knowledge transfer, increased efficiency in service delivery such as facilitating digital financing and contributing to improved health-care services. This has been evident especially in the periods of Covid-19 lockdowns where the majority of services were mainly accessible through ICT platforms. This customer base has been penetrated by supermarkets, electronic stores and home delivery companies. But due to the gender digital divide, women have lost a considerable share of their market due to limitations in embracing e-commerce tools and the lack of equipment or knowledge of utilizing emerging digital technologies.

Furthermore, the current status shown in Table 13 indicates a gender gap in access to internet at home comparing both male and female headed households in spite of overall limited access for both categories. Also, to note is an increase of such access when compared the period 2017/18 and 2021/22 estimated at 7.5% for male headed households and 4.3% for female headed households.

Table 13: Access to internet (per household) and digital literacy

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Household (female headed) having access to internet at home	18.5	13.2	26.0	17.5
Number of male and female graduates in ICT related courses in higher education)	782	457	-	-
Number of Teachers Trained in ICT (2018 and 2019)				
Primary School Teachers trained in ICT	4,534	5,333	4,398	5,360
Secondary School Teachers trained in ICT	5,239	2,071	4,938	1,917

Source: NISR (EICV5 and 6: Thematic Report on Utilities and Amenities), HEC, Administrative Data, 2021

² Twesige, D., Gasheja, F., Hategekimana, U., Nkubito, E. J., & Hitayezu, I. (2020). Analysis of causes of business failure in Rwanda: learning from small and medium enterprises (SMEs). *Readings Book*, 122.

³ Kasema, R. (2021). Key failure factors of start-up women owned SMEs in service sector in Kigali: a principal component analysis approach. *Vilakshan-XIMB Journal of Management*, (ahead-of-print).

According to the national statistics in Table 14, high usage of internet among men and women increases by age, thus implying an increasing interest of exploring new things using internet especially among young people (16 years and above). However, it seems to be critical to observe population with 10 years using internet due to changes in sexual behaviors among the adults including girls. This will call for more actions on the side of parents to ensure that children are well educated on the use of emerging ICT devices to avoid negative effects especially in their early ages. Robust cybersecurity interventions and policies need to be crafted to enhance the likelihood of productive utilization of the internet.

Table 14: Percentage of the population who used internet by district according to age groups

Indicators	4PHC 2012		5PHC 2022	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Population 10 years and above			16.6	11.2
Population 16 years and above			19.9	12.9
Population 21 years and above			21.3	13.1

Source: NISR, Population and Housing Census (5 RPHC, 2023).

In terms of the possession of mobile phones, TV sets, and radio posts, male headed households have more access to these communication devises than women as shown in Table 15 below. Looking at the change between the two periods, there is a 20.2% decline in female headed households while the ownership of mobile phones has not significantly and positively changed during the two periods of comparison. However, male headed households are still dominant in owning mobile phones (76.5%) against their counterpart women are estimated at an ownership level of 54.7%. Similarly, national statistics reveal that 82.4% and 67.4% of private households headed by male and female respectively have at least one member owning a mobile phone. This has some implications when it comes to use of phone for new technologies both in agriculture and services. Those with smart phones tend to benefit from new phone-based technologies being it in agriculture extension services or service deliveries like mobile marketing.

Table 15: Possession of mobile phones, TV and radio posts

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
Distribution of female headed owning mobile phones	71.1	54.3	76.5	54.7
Distribution of female and male having access to mobile phones	90.0	84.0	89.0	84.0
Households (female and male headed) owning TV set	11.9	5.7	9.5	3.5
Households (female and male headed) owning radio posts	78.6	59.3	64.4	39.1
Percentage of private households whose at least one member owns a mobile phone (male and female headed HHs)			82.4	67.4

Source: NISR (EICV4 & 5: Thematic Report on Utilities and Amenities); FinScope 2020: Gender and Financial Inclusion in Rwanda

It is encouraging to note that there are positive milestones emanating from deliberate government and partners' initiatives to enable women's participation in ICT related courses (such as HeforSHE impact commitment, She can Code, ICT specialized institutions, youth connect forum, and ICT facilities (i.e., internet connectivity related infrastructure). This is also facilitated by a policy and strategic framework including national digital talent policy and ICT in education policy. However, challenges remain in the realm of high level of computer illiteracy for both men and women, ICT use which is still perceived as an

elite business rather than a development tool, high cost of ICT courses as linked to people's purchasing power, and inadequate ICT infrastructure at different levels of education especially in primary, secondary, and TVET levels. Going forward, more interventions will need to focus on affordable ICT devices by both men and women, strengthen and scaling up of ICT facilities and infrastructure, and more partnerships between government, private service providers, schools, and communities to sensitize male and female students on embracing the use of ICT.

3.1.5. Access to finance

Continuing to facilitate access to finance by women remains a key intervention area provided by the NST-1 guidelines. Consequently, as shown in Table 16 below, there is a remarkable improvement in access to finance by both men and women through different financial products from mainly formal financial institutions during the review period (2017/18-2021/22). The access to finance opportunities have increased by 11% for women (from 63% to 74%) and by 7% for men (from 74% to 81%). Financial inclusion particularly for women has been driven by the gender responsive policy and legal frameworks including National Gender Policy 2010 revised in 2021 and National Inclusion Financial Strategy (2019-2024). However, more gains can still be recorded as the multiplier effects of economic transformation are transmitted through the various levels of the economy.

Table 16: Distribution of financial products/ services

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Men and women uptaking financial products/ services				
Financially included	90	86	93	92
Formally served	74	63	81	74
Informally served	71	71	76	80
Percentage of population who save				
Aged 18+ (formal and informal saving)				
Aged 18+ with formal saving	56	41	61	49
Aged 18+ with informal saving	55	57	61	66
Men and women applied to loan in commercial banks and micro-finance				

Source: AFR, FinScope Gender thematic report (2016 and 2020)

Provisions in the national gender policy center around access to finance through access to use of various bank products, increase absorption of existing and new financial products, design and implement financial literacy program for women and men, and ICT literacy to increase access to related services by women without prejudice to their daily responsibilities, among others. In the same logic, other on-going ICT related services to enable more financial inclusion include digitalization of financial services by financial institution such as e-banking, Momo, existence of tailored financial products and services specific for women (such as elevate in Ecobank and BK urumuri), women's guarantee fund which enables women to access loan/credit, and on-going Affirmative Finance Action for Women in Africa (AFAWA) and 50 million African Women speak.

Access to and utilization of formal savings accounts for male and female is considered as an effective way to ensure security of money and earning future interest. Currently, as shown in Table 17 below, it is observed that females are more likely to own a savings account in formal financial institutions (62%) as

compared to male (59%) their counterparts. However, the proportion of female with an active bank account in formal financial institutions is found to be low (19%) compared to the proportion of male with active bank account (26%). There is need to further understand the velocity of funds in these accounts and the amounts that are kept by the clients.

Table 17: Distribution of bank clients per sex (%)

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Female and male owning a saving account in formal financial institutions	50	46	59	62
Female and male holding an active bank account in formal financial institutions	-	-	26	19

Source: GMO, Gender profile in access to finance (2023)

The number of accounts owned by men is higher than number of women's accounts and this number increased between the two periods (2020 and 2022) as summarized in Table 18. This indicator does not elaborate how these accounts are managed in terms of their use, especially in terms of the need to hold several accounts. Men have received more loans in terms of number and amount than women. This can be linked to the fact that men have more access on productive assets (i.e. land, livestock), considered as collateral for the bank loans, than their women counterparts. Over the period from 2020 to 2022, the amount of loans has increased by 16.5% for men and by 43% for women. The higher increase for the women is a positive step towards inclusive financial services using the gender lenses. Continuing to push the interventions supporting inclusive financing should take center priority going forward while adopting other non-asset collateral requirements by formal financial institutions.

Table 18: Ownership of accounts, number and amount of loans received by bank clients

Indicators	2020		2022	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Number of accounts owned	8,436	6,808	9,909	8,601
Number of loans accounts	1,380	906	826	682
Number of loans	343,565	92,964	506,377	174,328
Amount loans (in thousands of Rwf)	337,088,796	82,432,112	392,619,377	117,879,546

Source: National Bank of Rwanda (BNR) Administrative data (2022)

In spite of financial inclusion remaining a top priority for Rwanda as far as women's access to finance is concerned, meeting the standard expectations of sustainable access to finance models faces some persistent challenges and constraints. These include limited access to credit due to lack of collateral security, limited control by women over household assets (i.e., land and houses), social norms influencing women to access finances, limited financial literacy hindering women and men to request for credits, and high cost of the capital as compared to returns on investment for micro-projects which are in most cases not consistent with the economic conditions within a particular sector of interest. These challenges have multi-dimensional implications in respect of women's productivity, creation of decent jobs by both men and women, and financial resilience to withstand potential shocks.

3.2. Social transformation

Rwanda aspires to become a Middle-Income Country by 2035 and a high-income country by 2050. The ongoing NST-1 interventions will build a foundation towards this national orientation. The core pillar promotes coping, adaptation, mitigation and resilience to shocks; and enhanced graduation from poverty and extreme poverty. To achieve this, there are mechanisms to improve and scale up core and complementary social protection programs. Driving interventions focus to improving health care services at all levels, strengthening financial sustainability of the health sector, and enhancing capacity of health workforce and strategic investments in all levels of education with improved teachers' welfare. The state of gender equality in this pillar is assessed along these areas: education, health, social protection, and access to water and energy.

3.2.1. Education

Access to education for both boys and girls as well as men and women is critical for human capital development, a critical pillar in Vision 2050. The government has invested and established various mechanisms to ensure equal access to education by both boys and girls: school feeding programme, access to 9- and 12-years basic education, girls' rooms at schools, girls' education policy, early childhood development centers, digitalization of education especially during Covid-19, education grants, and increased infrastructure for learning facilities including those for learners with disabilities. These interventions have translated into increased access to education for both girls and boys and men and women in the adult education frameworks. Statistics from a recent Population Census report (NISR, 2023) show a sustained increase in the access for girls up to 90.3% and 88.4% of boys within the age category of 6-11 years who attend school (see Table 19).

Table 19: Enrolment of students (boys and girls) at all levels of education

Indicators	CGSR 2019					CGSR 2023					Variation (%)	
	Male	Female	Total	Male %	Female %	Male	Female	Total	Male %	Female %	Male	Female
Pre-primary	112,044	114,662	226,706	49.42	50.58	143,060	150,763	293,823	48.7	51.3	(0.73)	0.73
Primary	1,259,344	1,244,361	2,503,705	50.30	49.70	1,370,022	1,359,094	2,729,116	50.2	49.8	(0.10)	0.10
Secondary	308,367	349,918	658,285	46.84	53.16	363,214	419,632	782,846	46.4	53.6	(0.45)	0.45
Technical Vocational Education and training (TVET)	56,708	40,527	97,235	58.32	41.68	57,100	45,293	102,393	55.8	44.2	(2.56)	2.56
High learning (Universities)	51,119	3,8041	89,160	57.33	42.67	48,757	39,691	88,448	55.1	44.9	(2.21)	2.21

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

More specifically, the enrollment of girls in 2021 is more elaborately observed in pre-primary and secondary level as compared to boys with an estimate of 51.3% and 53.6% in the two levels respectively. They are however lowly enrolled or represented when it comes to primary (49.8%), TVET (44.2%), and High Learning Institutions (44.9%). Part of the explanation is the increased rate of dropout rate for girls in the lower and upper secondary levels estimated at 11.1% and 8.3% respectively. These have increased from 7.7% and 1.6% respectively as compared to 2019. This is in part explained by low performance rate for girls and boys who attend national exams (S3 and S6, thus limiting them to continue to the next level of education. Other explanatory factors of dropout comprise early pregnancies among adolescent girls also connected with

stigmatization and financial pressure, long distance from home to schools⁴, poverty levels, and late enrolment especially for those who start primary at high age compared to the normal starting age.

The enrollment of girl students with disabilities is lower compared to male students with disability (see Table 20). One observes an increasing drop of girl students with disabilities as one moves from pre-primary to higher learning education.

Table 20: Enrolment of students with disabilities (at all levels) in 2021

Indicators	CGSR 2019					CGSR 2023					Variation (%)	
	Male	Female	Total	Male %	Female %	Male	Female	Total	Male %	Female %	Male	Female
Pre-primary	743	510	1253	59.3	40.7	1,297	923	2,220	58.4	41.6	-0.9	0.9
Primary	9,669	7,464	17,133	56.4	43.6	13,027	10,400	23,427	55.6	44.4	-0.8	0.8
Secondary	2,253	2,304	4,557	49.4	50.6	2,088	1,885	3,973	52.6	47.4	3.1	-3.1
Technical Vocational Education and training (TVET)	254	235	489	51.9	48.1	281	197	478	58.8	41.2	6.8	-6.8
High learning (Universities)	98	75	173	56.6	43.4	80	39	119	67.2	32.8	10.6	-10.6

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

Similarly, the representation of girls in STEM is lower at 46.2% compared to 53.8% of boys though with a slight increment of 0.6% during the period 2019-2022. Nevertheless, there is a positive change for girls 'enrollment at all levels ranging between 0.73% (pre-primary) and 2.21% (Universities).

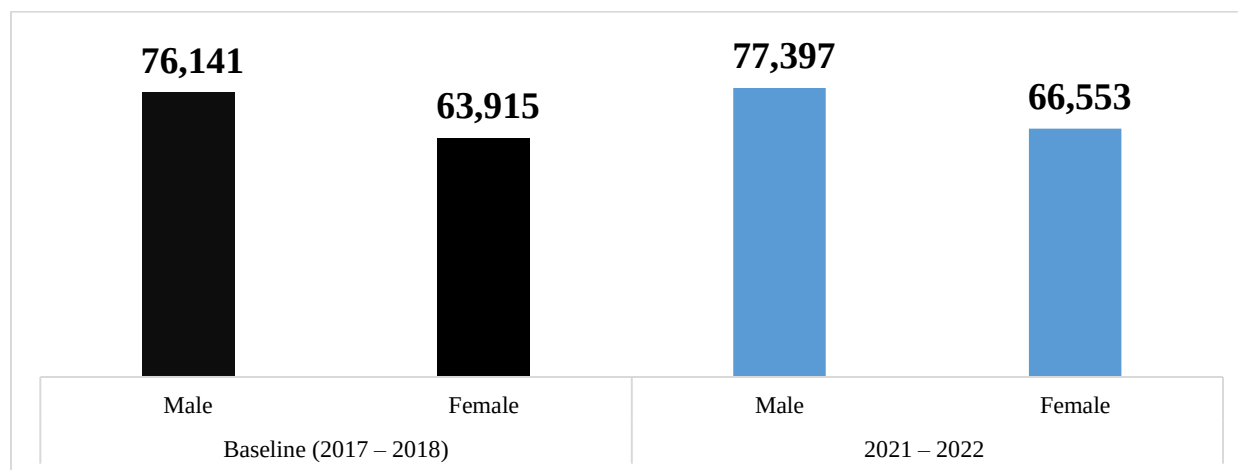


Figure 5: Distribution of boys and girls in STEM (Upper Secondary)

Source: NISR Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

Results in Table 21 show that, with regard to teachers' representation, women are more dominant in pre-primary (85.6%) and in primary education (56.9%) levels while men are more represented in secondary

⁴ Needs an estimate of the distance from the nearest school.

(68.3%) and higher learning education (81.0%). This reveals a gender gap in respective teachers' salaries as they are greater in secondary school and higher learning institutions.

Table 21: Teachers (male and female) distribution at all levels of education

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Pre-primary	994	5,286	1,154	6,880
Primary	20,161	23,780	27,100	35,813
Secondary	16,283	6,683	21,792	10,118
Technical Vocational Education and training (TVET level 1-5)	3,684	1,481	3,745	1,536
Technical Vocational Education and training (TVET level 6-7)	1,172	270	1,158	272
Academic staff for tertiary education	2,233	606	2,233	606
High learning (Universities)	81.4	18.6	81	19

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

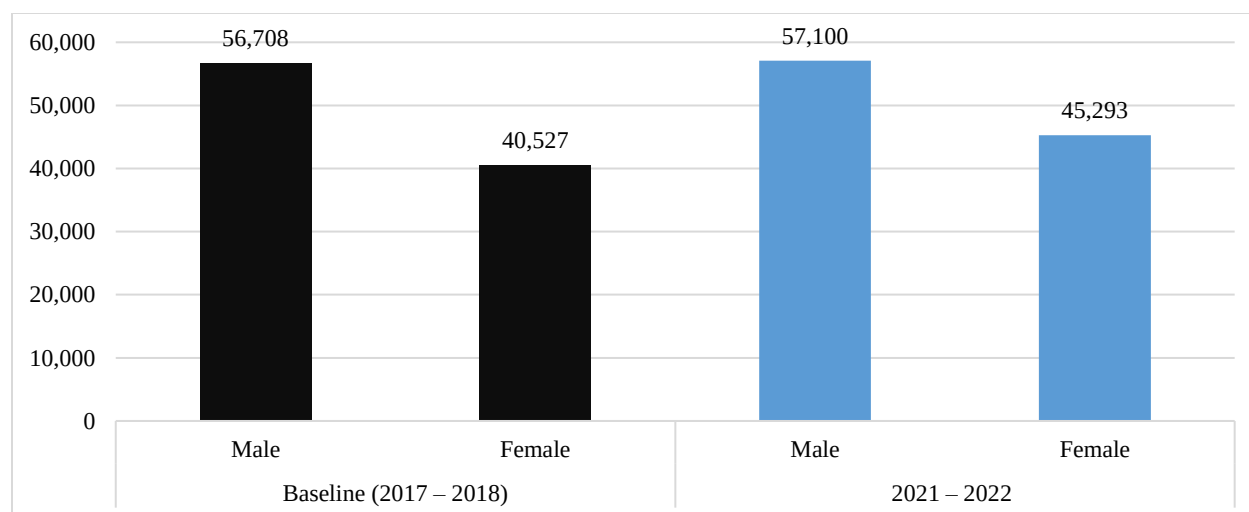


Figure 6: Distribution of boys and girls in Technical Vocational Education and training (level 1-7)

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

Overall, gross and net attendance rate in primary and secondary schools has significantly increased over the two periods as shown in Table 22 below. In primary school, these rates surpassed 100% because of high attendance rate in pre-primary schools resulted mainly to the implementation of SDGs goal related to education for all. With this goal, removal or reduction of education cost has accelerated attendance rate in pre-primary school in the last couple of years. However, of concern is that, this is also a sign of delayed enrolment tendencies in most schools especially in the rural areas of Rwanda. There is thus need to aggressively support Early Childhood Development (ECD) programmes to strengthen foundational learning and encourage timely enrolment in schools. Additionally, parents, especially the fathers must be encouraged to place education at the center of household level and national level transformation processes. All this should lead to higher Net Enrolment Rate and reduce the Gross Enrolment Rates to at most 100%. At the tail end, this will also ultimately reduce cases of children who stay completely out of school for various gender sensitive school and social factors.

Table 22: Gross, net attendance rates (%) in primary school level (6-11 years) and in secondary education (12-17 years) by sex

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Gross attendance ⁵ rate in primary school level (6-11 years)	139.0	136.1	150.5	149.1
Net attendance rate in primary school level (6-11 years)	98.0	98.5	98.7	99.1
Gross attendance rate in secondary education (12-17 years)	37.5	41.7	40.7	46.4
Net attendance rate in secondary education (12-17 years)	32.1	28.2	31.7	37.5

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021), 5th Rwanda Population and Housing Census, 2023)

Dropout rate among male and female primary and secondary students is getting more increased overtime as indicated in Table 23 below. The highest dropout rate is observed for male and female who attended upper secondary education, from 1.9% to 7.1% and from 1.6% to 8.3% for male and female respectively. This increase can be partly explained by a lack of financial ability, by poor households, required to cover education related expenses. In the same context, poverty level among households in Rwanda has increased due to Covid-19 pandemic and Russia-Ukraine war which affected imports volume of mostly consumed commodities and definitely raised inflation rate.

Table 23: Boys and girls dropout rate at all levels

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Primary	7	6.3	11.3	7.7
Lower Secondary	6.5	7.7	10.9	11.1
Upper Secondary	1.9	1.6	7.1	8.3

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

National exam pass rate at all levels

Table 24 below shows that there is a slight but encouraging increase of passing rate among primary, lower and upper secondary and TVET students between the two periods (2018 and 2021).

Table 24: Students (boys and girls) passing national S3, S6 and TVET exams

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Primary (from P6 to S1)	79.9	82.2	80.9	84.4
Lower secondary (S3)	85.7	81.1	87.8	85.3
Upper secondary (S6)	91.9	82.8	93.2	86.5
TVET	95.9	92.8	97.2	96.0

Source: National Examination and School Inspection Authority (NESA), 2021

The GoR, through MINEDUC, made remarkable progresses necessary to improve transition rate over the past years. However, the transition rate between the final year of primary and the first year of secondary is not on track and the transition rate from lower secondary to upper secondary declined between the two periods for male and female (see Table 25). Despite the decline of this rate in primary and secondary levels, there is an increase of the transition rate from upper secondary to higher education for both male and female.

⁵ In statistical yearbook “attendance” refers to “enrolment”

Table 25: Transition rate (%)

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Transition rate (boys and girls) from primary to lower secondary	72.3	71.0	65.6	66.3
Transition rate (boys and girls) from lower secondary to upper secondary	88.7	82.5	80.3	75.0
Transition rate (boys and girls) from upper secondary to higher education	52.8	45.0	71.5	54.7

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021).

One of the Education Sector Strategic Plan (ESSP) 2018-2024 priorities is “*strengthened modern school infrastructure and facilities across all levels of education in Rwanda*”. Statistics presented in Table 26 below show that schools (primary, secondary and TVET) have facilities that are necessary to improve the quality of the study environment in the school. However, the modernity of these infrastructure still remains an issues that needs further investment and gendering efforts, especially for the schools located in the rural areas of Rwanda.

Table 26: Infrastructure/ Access to sanitation facilities

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Access to sanitation facilities/ distribution of girls’ room at all levels (as enabling conditions)				
Primary schools				1,691
Secondary schools				1,189
TVET schools				220
Distribution of rest rooms				
Nursery			6,208	6,314
Primary			25,894	26,653
Secondary +TVET			18,702	18,145
Distribution of female and male registered or having access to e-learning	1,158	772	797	687

Source: NISR (Statistical Yearbook: Education, 2021); HEC and MINEDUC, Administrative Data (2021)

There is evidence that a high proportion of students who complete secondary education do not have financial abilities to pay for the higher education level. To bridge these financial challenges, the majority apply for a scholarship, to study either locally or abroad. Of concern is that, the data from MINEDUC (see Table 27) reveals that the number and value of awarded scholarships to study locally have declined for male students and slightly increased for female students due to the girl child empowerment initiatives, mainly from the international organizations including the MasterCard Foundation, Bill and Mellissa Gate foundation among others. This is all happening at a time when the scholarships for studying abroad have declined for both male and female students over the last two years. A possible immediate explanation can be derived from the declining performance of the traditional funding economies including Sweden, United Kingdom and United States of America as they deal with recovery programmes post the Covid-19 pandemic. A similar pattern is observed where the number of males and females using e-learning facilities has decreased over the same period. All these realities paint a picture where there is need to further realign the interventions to support access to digital content while also supporting access to upstream levels of the education value chain. These strategies are discussed under the ICT section earlier in this report as possible gateways to enhancing appropriateness of ICT infrastructure for schools, parents, support organizations and communities alike.

Table 27: Distribution of scholarships and use of ICT in education

Indicators	2020- 2021		2021-2022	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Distribution of scholarships – Local students	7,925	5,009	7,658	5,034
Distribution of scholarships – Abroad	267	116	210	89
Number of male and female graduates in ICT related courses in higher education (all levels)	1,551	1,000		
Number of males and females using e-learning (online mode of delivery only)	353	311	218	251
Number of students by blended mode of delivery at all levels (both online and face to face mode of delivery)	28,405	23,038	31,857	23,675

Source: Administrative data, MINEDUC (2023).

Box 1: Rwanda has achieved gender parity in primary and secondary schools

Overall, this state of gender equality report documents a commendable progress in terms of gender parity in access to education both at primary and secondary schools. Rwanda has achieved gender parity at primary and secondary levels. There is no discrimination of girls in attending any domain of study; both girls and boys have equal rights to access education at all levels. There is also a greater consideration by the government in facilitating children with disabilities or from poor families to access education through existing social protection schemes.

The central concern will be to ensure that the training received by women and girls prepares them for the current and future entrepreneurship and employment opportunities, enables women and girls to benefits ICT related services and opportunities. However, it is reiterated that gender disparities persistent especially in areas of tertiary, ICT, STEM, and TVET education at all levels and among women and girls due to the following main reasons:

- the choice of soft trades by girls in TVET (girls focusing on tailoring, hair dressing, welding while boys are predominantly in areas such as construction, carpentry, motor mechanics, electricity).
- traditional beliefs and stereotypes prevailing within the Rwandan society that STEM subjects are difficult and are meant for boys.
- early marriage and childbearing increase the workload and responsibilities of women and girls, both students and teachers, hence contributing to a relatively low representation of women and girls both as students and teaching academic staff at universities and Polytechnics.

Failing to ensure gender parity in these areas of education has some negative implications re women's economic empowerment. These comprise limited women's capital development and limited ability to gain from the benefits that offer education in ICT, STEM, and TVET both in terms of increased competencies but also in terms of decent employment. The focus for policy actions should continue to bridge the gender divide in these particular areas by increasing female enrollment and completion in these programs, promoting competence-based gender responsive programs by increasing the female dividend in trades with more labor market potentials.

3.2.2. Health

A healthy population is instrumental both in terms of productivity and people's improved livelihood. This sub-section explores gender equality with regard to health mirrored though access to health insurance, mortality rate, and access to services such as antenatal and family planning, nutrition status.

Health Insurance

Cognizant of the overall improvement of the life expectancy from 64.5 years old in 2012 to 69.6 years old; more actions are needed to sustain such rapid progress by assuring sustainability of access to health insurance, reduce the child mortality rate, and improve the nutritional status for both men and women as well as girls and boys. Results from this status analysis in Table 28 reveal an overall good trend in access to health insurance for both women (82.6%) and men (83.2%). There is no significant difference observed between men and women. This is partly explained by increased community level mobilization of people to adhere the insurance scheme coupled with increased awareness of related benefits, and consideration of Community Based Health Insurance Scheme (CBHI) in annual performance targets (*Imihigo*). However, the trend in access to CBHI known as *Mutuelle de santé* has slightly declined when compared to the status in 2019, changing downward from 94.1% to 77.2% for women and from 94.0% to 77.5% for men. The access to private led insurance services is generally lower for both categories – men and women-with insignificant difference. These patterns are worrying given that they signal negative movements relative to already attained targets.

Table 28: Health insurance coverage among men and women population aged 15- 49 years

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Men	Women	Men	Women
Distribution of female and male population having access to health insurance	72.9	74.0	83.2	82.6
Mutuelle de santé (Mutual/Community)	94.0	94.1	77.5	77.2
RAMA/RSSB	4.4	4.2	4.2	3.6
MMI	0.4	0.7	0.8	1.2
Private Commercial Insurance Companies	0.8	0.6	0.8	0.6
Others Medical insurance (FARG)	0.4	0.2	0.3	0.1
None	-	-	16.8	17.4

Source: NISR: RDHS2014/15, RDHS 2019/20

The observed decline in access to CBHI as reported above may negatively affect the state of health-related outcomes earlier achieved such as improved status in infant and under-5 mortality rates as well as maternal mortality ratio (see Table 29). The rate of child mortality (14%) is higher for girls as compared to boys (12%) and the rate of under 5 mortalities (47%) is higher for boys as compared to girls (43%). With respect to infant mortality, the rate for girls stands at 30% against 35% of boys. In these instances, it is critical to trace the benefits emanating from a vibrant and inclusive health insurance coverage schemes coupled with improved services in the health sector. Because of these milestones, child mortality has decreased from 26 deaths to 14 deaths per 1000 live births for girls and from 27 to 12 deaths per 1000 live births for boys. These multi thronged milestones need to be sustained by individual, local and national level behavior changes that support resilient institutions and operational procedures in Rwanda. The Human Capital Index (HCI) computations can also help to trace problem areas that are intertwined across different sectors including health and education, as a way of designing more robust interventions.

Table 29: Mortality rate (Deaths per 1,000 live births in the 5-year period before the survey)

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Maternal Mortality Ratio⁶		210		203
Infant mortality	-	-	35	30
Child mortality	27	26	12	14
Under - 5 mortality	-	-	47	43

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

Nutrition

The GoR has implemented a number of initiatives to deal with malnutrition related issues, especially the stunting among children: A support in supplementary fortified food given is given to poor families with malnourished and pregnant women, there is provision of one cow per poor family to address malnutrition among other connected benefits, and education on nutrition through the established National Early Childhood Development Program (NECDP), and encouragement of home gardens.

Despite the above initiatives, the nutrition status (prevalence of stunting) for female children under 5 years' age has not changed over the two periods. It stands currently at 29.2% similar to 29.4% as shown in Table 30 below. For male children, the stunting level has increased from 35.5% to 37% during the period 2019-2023. The level of obesity for women has slightly increased from 22.4% to 26.3% while the mean body mass index (BMI) for women has slightly increased from 22.8 to 23.3% during the period from 2019 to 2020. These trends have some negative implications such as reduced performance capacity both for men or boys and women or girls, low school performance for both malnourished boys and girls, increased costs and time of caring for malnourished children both for the family and the added burden to government support.

Table 30: Nutritional status of child (under 5 years of age), women and men

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Prevalence of stunting among children under 5 years of age	35.5	29.4	37.0	29.2
Prevalence of wasting among children under 5 years of age	1.7	1.7	0.9	1.4
Prevalence of overweight among children under 5 years of age	12	12.2	9	6.3
Mean body mass index (BMI) of men and women age 15 – 49	21.1	22.8	-	23.3

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

To improve the nutrition status among men and women as well as boys and girls, more policy actions are needed to accelerate home grown approaches to improve nutritional knowledge with the communities, limited access to productive resources, increase the production of nutrition dense food (both crops and livestock), continued promotion of consumption of supplementary micronutrients, and increased intervention to address stunting among children under five. years The nutrition role is increasingly being assigned to women as driven by social norms and tradition, nutrition related interventions/programmes

⁶ The estimated maternal mortality ratio is 203 deaths per 100,000 live births during the 5-year period before the survey

should deliberately be gender sensitive and involve women at different levels of decisions, programming, and practices.

Family planning and reproductive health

The government of Rwanda and partners aim to scale up efforts to raise awareness on family planning and reproductive health. The NST-1 target is to increase contraceptive prevalence from 48% (2013/14) to 60% in 2024 (GoR, 2017). Planned interventions to achieve this target include ensuring universal access to conceptive information and service to avoid unplanned pregnancies and prevention of sexually transmitted diseases with a particular focus on the youth.

The levels of access to antenatal care services are very satisfactory with an estimate of 99% as shown in Table 31. On the use of any contraceptive method by married women for the age category of 15-49 years old, the rate varies at 64.1%. Discriminatory gendered social norms have been identified playing a major influence in hindering the effective uptake of health services including family planning by men and sexual and reproductive health for young people. This calls for cultural and context specific program to help young people and especially men navigate their sexual, reproductive health, and family planning. Furthermore, amplified programmatic interventions for sexual reproductive health services (SRHS) for adolescents are critically necessary for reducing unwanted pregnancies and pregnancy-related school dropout.

Table 31: Women Receiving Antenatal Care from a Skilled Provider (age category) and family planning among currently married women

Indicators	CGSR 2019	CGSR 2023
Women Receiving Antenatal Care		
<20		98.9
20-34		97.8
35-49		97.3
Overall	99.0	97.7
Family planning among currently married women		
Women aged 15 – 49 using any contraceptive method	53.2	64.1
Women aged 15 – 49 using modern contraceptive method	47.5	58.4
Women aged 15 – 49 using traditional contraceptive method	5.8	5.7

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

A summary of the age at first marriage in Rwanda is presented in Table 32 below. There were mixed findings from male and female categories over the review period, with the median age for males in the 30 to 59-year category slightly increasing from 25.4 to 25.8 years while that for females in the same category was at 22.5 years. The median age for females in the 25 to 49-year category also marginally increased from 21.9 to 22.8 years. These increases can be attributed to changes in the citizens' view of the marriage institution and thus deciding to wait until they are economically stable and self-sufficient before getting married. A more socially oriented approach will also support this shift while further encouraging both girls and boys to be economically active before committing to the marriage arrangements. Possible target people include school dropouts, children who are completely not schooled, religious clusters which encourage early marriage as well as Higher Education Institutions (TVET and Universities) where higher levels of independence can be a breeding area for teenage pregnancies.

Table 32: Age at first marriage (women and men)

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Median age at first marriage among men and women age 25-49	a ⁷	21.9	a	22.8
Median age at first marriage among women and men age 30-59	25.4	a	25.8	22.5

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

3.2.3. Social protection

The right to social protection in Rwanda is well provided for within the Constitution of the GoR. Specifically, to the sub-sector, the government has designed a specific policy (2020) and strategic plan (2022) for social protection and sustainable graduation from poverty. The aim is to reduce vulnerability of marginalized people, enhancing capacity for the poor, and creating economic opportunities for poverty escapes for the poor and vulnerable (Anna Ornnert, 2020).

Rwanda has several social protection schemes grouped under the Village Umurenge Program (VUP), community health insurance, and pension programme. All programmes and poverty alleviation schemes are implemented with support from several strategic partners, either through direct financial and technical support or through partner implementing non-government organizations (NGOs).

The assessment of gender equality and equity status under this particular thematic area focuses on women and men's representation in social protection programmes implemented through the Village Umurenge programme (VUP), the pension programme, and health insurance in the context of social security coverage because the access component is already addressed under the health sub-section 3.2.2. The descriptive analysis shows that men are only dominant when it comes to classic public works under VUP and women are the most beneficiaries of other VUP components such as VUP financial services, expanded public works, minimum package for graduation, and direct support. Table 33 shows that, overall, women are the most beneficiaries of the VUP social protection scheme (58.7%) as compared to men (41.3%). While social protection schemes targeting women are important, high numbers of women beneficiaries give a signal that women are the majority being affected by different dimensions of poverty. The active involvement of women in the VUP classic public works is likely to offer more job opportunities mainly in the areas of community infrastructure projects such as terracing irrigation, building of classrooms, construction of access roads, to mention but a few. In addition, despite their eligibility to these programmes, many women find their participation in VUP Public Works (supposed to be the most remunerating) very limited due to their full involvement in unpaid care work. Consistent with field level consultations in the context of this study, certain categories of women are not eligible to this programme such as expectant mothers and teen mothers who are left out in such projects. Consequently, they end up being considered in the VUP expanded public work or VUP direct support categories. More investment in women and girls' education and generation of alternative employment opportunities for women is critical to ensure that women escape and stay out of poverty in the mid and long-term.

⁷ Omitted because less than 50% of the women or men began living with their spouse or partner for the first time before reaching the beginning of the age group

Table 33: Number of VUP beneficiaries by component (public works, direct support, financial services) and gender

VUP components	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
VUP Financial service	41,500	43,194	24,537	25,538
VUP Classic Public works	90,139	81,554	90,972	77,877
VUP Expanded Public Works	10,650	31,402	15,069	43,324
Households that received Minimum Package for Graduation (MPG) asset transfers.	4,185	4,720	3,917	4,416
VUP Direct Support	33,465	85,560	33,133	86,665

Source: LODA, Annual Reports 2022.

A look at the status of gender equality in social security programmes, apart from the coverage in health insurance schemes, gender disparity remains observed on other social security programs such as pension insurance, and occupational hazard pension as well as reflected in the proportion of the amount of money received by men and women. Though the positive trends shown in Table 34 below for both men and women, there are limiting factors for women's equal participation in the pension schemes including high employment in the informal sector making difficult to adhere to the national pension insurance, multidimensional poverty affecting their ability to gather the premium that is required, and insurance literacy among others.

Table 34: Beneficiaries of social security programs

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Number of men and women covered by Community Health Insurance (Mutuelle de Sante)	5,051,178	5,334,748	5,111,284	5,386,843
Number of individuals covered by RSSB/RAMA Health Insurance	277,300	258,254	282,567	263,095
Number of Pension insurance contributors by sex	398,085	188,487	465,326	233,715
Number of Pension beneficiaries by sex	22,508	16,741	24,820	17,534
Number of occupational Hazard pension beneficiaries	1,688	1,255	1,849	1,306
Proportion Amount of money received by men and women beneficiaries of Pension program	71.83%	28.17%	71.75%	28.25%

Source: RSSB, Administrative Data (2022)

Overall, social protection and security schemes by the government and private sector are meant to support people escape out of poverty. A tremendous effort has been made to reduce extreme poverty from 36% in 2006 to 16% in 2017. Despite this significant reduction, poverty remains a concern and women tend to be the most affected. Part of response is that the design of these social protection programmes is not well tailored to a comprehensive gender gap analysis, limiting consideration of gender dimensions on sex disaggregated numbers often reported post interventions. In addressing poverty and ensure graduation out of poverty, social protection is well considered as a key driving factors which help people get out of multidimensional poverty in Rwanda. Other factors that would enable specifically women get out of poverty include the following: reinforcing female's education and intensifying women's employment opportunities, and health coverage (such as Bigirimana and Sun, 2020; Uwizeye et al., 2022; Bizoza et al., 2018). In the same line, women's graduation out of poverty will have to leverage on the new strategy for sustainable

graduation enacted by the Ministry of Local Governance (MINALOC, 2022). The targeting of women with special needs will add value to their graduation.

People with disabilities by gender

The government of Rwanda continues to support people with various types of disabilities to improve their livelihoods. Therefore, the assessment of progress on gender equality among people with disabilities goes with the philosophy of ‘leave no one behind’ or inclusion. Cognizant of differentials in gender equality among men and women across the thematic areas considered, the disability adds burden to pre-existing gender gaps. Looking at the statistics of the previous EICV5, there is no significant difference in percentage of men and women with disabilities apart from the disability in legs where men are dominant (see Table 33). Other studies (e.g., Kidd & Kabare, 2019) have revealed that working age persons with disabilities are disadvantaged in the labour market. Table 35 shows that, labour force participation among females is lower (49%) compared to males with disabilities (56%). Clearly, this thematic area lacks updated data and information to appreciate and accurately trace the gender parity. Therefore, it is recommended to have a specific gender profile for people with disabilities across the sectors in order to inform the decision-making in the planning and programme design targeting gender equality, equity, and women’s empowerment in support of government’s goal of inclusion in the national transformation.

Table 35: Distribution of people with disabilities by gender

Percentage of people who have difficulty in functioning according to domain:	2021 – 2022	
	Male	Female
Seeing	-	19.3
Hearing	-	5.8
Communicating	-	1.3
Walking or climbing steps	-	9.7

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

3.2.4. Gender equality in Access to Water and Energy

This sub-section presents the gender equality status in the area of access to water and energy in Rwanda. These are fundamental needs and they are considered critical in the NST1’s objective: Transition to a modern Rwandan household in urban and rural areas. Interventions include scaling up access to water from 87.4% to 100% and from 34% to 100% for access to electricity both in urban and rural areas by 2024.

Gender and access to water

Access to water, electricity, and sanitation are vital for people’s livelihoods. The current population census reports 82.3% of the Rwandan population having access to improved drinking water (NISR, 2023). Households headed by male have a slightly higher access to sources of clean water (82.7%) with a 1.1% difference when compared to women (81.4%). One observes insignificant difference between the two periods and between male and female headed households. Moreover, there is no significant difference in using water within a distance of 200 m (urban area) and 500 m (in rural areas) for both categories – male and female headed households. Overall, only 34.4% access water within a 200 m distance compare to 60% who can access water within a 500 m distance.

Looking at these statistics from the gender lens, the status remains mixed and the women's water fetching responsibility and time-use burden are yet obvious but also strategically worth for a policy discussion and consideration. Though numbers are somewhat equal, yet only 34.4 % of male headed households and 34.2% of women headed households can access drinking water within the acceptable standard distance of 200 m to main source of drinking water in the urban area. The trend in rural areas though satisfactory (60% for male and 60.7% female headed households) but it remains with gaps for improvement as access to water becomes central.

These facts from statistics supported by opinion from consultations support the traditional role of women and girls of fetching water remaining dominant in rural areas, where tap water or protected water sources are limited. The long distance to water sources explains why men may not fetch water for the household, indicating substantial scope to improve the attitudes of boys and men. Therefore, limited proximity to clean water sources increases women and children's time spent in fetching water leading to poor school performance for school children, water borne diseases especially for children and increased unpaid care work for women and hygiene among families.

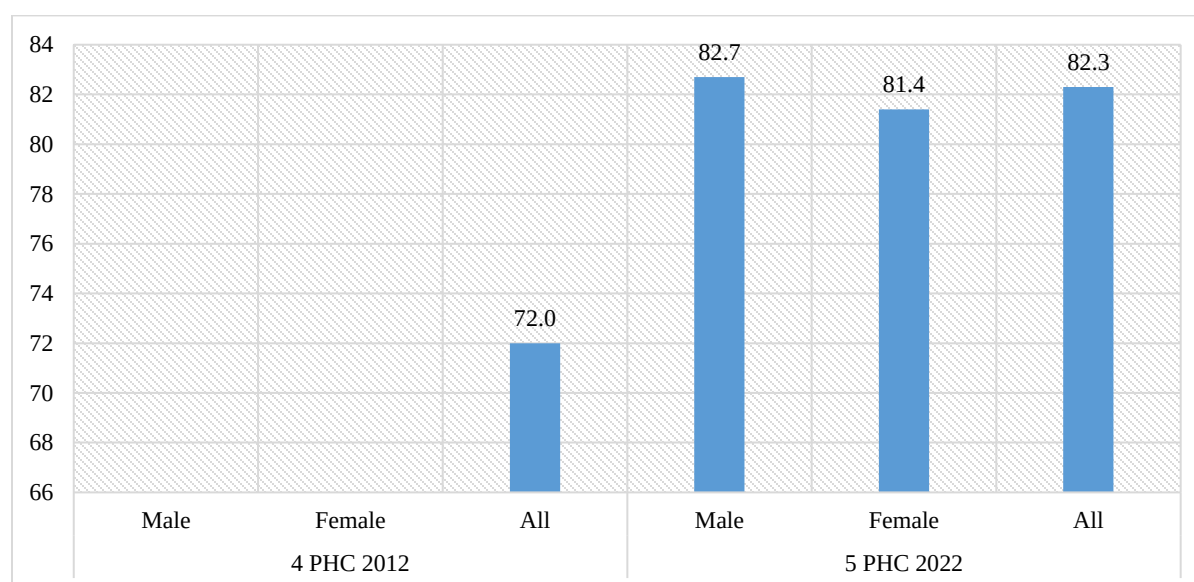


Figure 7: Percentage of private households that have access to improved drinking water

Source: NISR, Rwanda Population and Housing Census (RPHC 4&5), 2012 and 2022

With respect to access to improved sanitation, male headed households (85.9%) have more access than women headed households (76.5%) as shown in Figure 8 below. The status in 2017/18 has reduced by 4.1% for female headed households compared to 2.4% of male headed households.

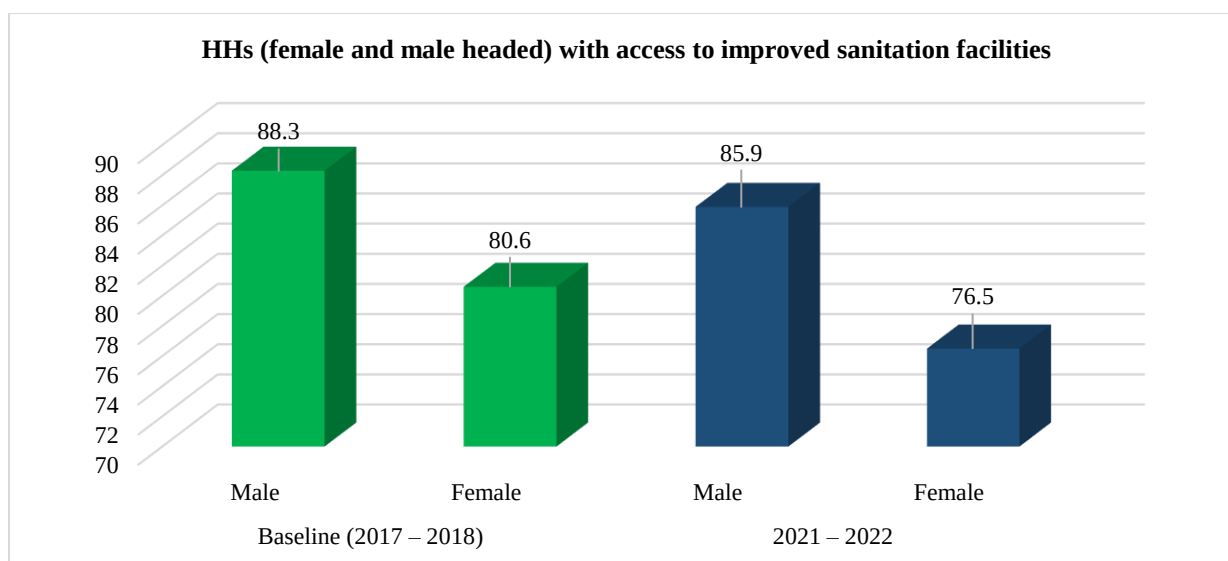


Figure 8: Household with access to improved and shared sanitation facilities

Source: NISR, Rwanda Population and Housing Census (RPHC 4&5), 2012 and 2022

Gender and access to energy

With respect to access to energy, male headed households are the majority to use electricity (29.4%) compared to 20.3% of female headed households (see Table 36). The majority of female (87.5%) and male (78.3%) headed households use firewood as the main source of energy though female users remains dominant. This status needs to be improved to facilitate women access to environmentally friendly energy both for lighting and cooking as this saves more time when compared to heavy reliance on charcoal and firewood.

Table 36: Access to electricity

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023		5RPHC 2022
	Male	Female	Male	Female	All
HHs (female and male headed) having access to electricity (as main source of lightning)	29.4	20.3	63.9	54.0	61.0
HHs (female and male headed) having access to energy for cooking gas, firewood, charcoal)					
Gas	1.2	0.9			4.6
Firewood	78.3	84.7			76.1
Charcoal	18.9	13			17.3
Percentage of private households, which have and used energy saving stove			32.4	31.8	32.2

Source: NISR: Thematic Report on Utilities Amenities (EICV5)

This status on access to water, energy, and sanitation has women's health implications in the form of spinal injury, neck pain, spontaneous abortion from heavy and awkward workloads, and caloric expenditure (Kayser et al. 2019). Accordingly, when girls carry water over long distances, the time available to them to pursue education is reduced. Water-fetching responsibilities also add to the burden of unpaid domestic work, decrease time towards other income-generating activities and affect the time for leisure and

nonessential activities. Therefore, when these basic needs (water, energy, and sanitation) are not met, women and girls find difficult to cope with the demands for livelihoods and are unable to participate and benefit equally in societal transformation. More actions are needed to ensure more gender responsive interventions in promoting easy access to water, energy, and sanitation services for both men and women in Rwanda. Furthermore, the planning should consider both notions of access, namely physical access (nearest source or availability) and economic access also translated in women and men's purchasing power.

3.3. Transformational governance

The overarching goal for the transformational governance in Rwanda is to consolidate good governance and justice as, building blocks for equitable and sustainable national development. Therefore, the discourse on women's participation in governance entails a call for more reflection on how power is distributed and used between men and women, determining who as decision-making power, how other players make their voices heard, and how accountability is given (Zambia GSR -2017/2019). Thus, equal participation of women and men in governance and decision-making is key to achieving sustainable development.

Rwanda has instituted women's representation and participation in decision-making at all levels. The current national constitution provides for a minimum representation quota for women of at least 30% and this is combined with a strong political will, gender responsive policies and legal environment as well as enhancement of capacity and mentorship for women led to increase their representation in decision making organs and improved gender responsiveness of development programmes. This section, thus, provides an update on the current status of women's participation, particularly in the legislature, executive, and judiciary; local government; public and quasi-public institutions; as well as households. The section also provides the status on GBV which is often treated as part of the governance pillar in terms of planning.

3.3.1. Participation of women in the legislature

The status of women's representation in the legislature (both parliament and senate) remained unchanged for the period 2017/18 and 2022/23 as highlighted in Table 37 below. Positive observables are women's majority representation in the parliament (61%) compared to men (39%). For the Senate, women are less represented at 38% against 62% of men. The fact that these positions are subject to elections yet to be conducted in 2024, this explains partly why the trend has remained constant over the evaluation period. Nevertheless, these trends reflect the political will in compliance with the proposed constitutional quotas of at least 30% women's representation in decision-making organs, and an innovative electoral framework. This has positive implications especially the assurance of mainstreaming gender by empowering women in legal reforms and eliminating gender bias in Rwanda's laws, key legislations, and government priorities.

Table 37: Participation of women in the legislature

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Members of Parliament in the Chamber of Deputies	39.0	61.0	39.0	61.0
Members of Parliament in chamber of Senate	62.0	38.0	62.0	38.0

Source: NISR - National Gender Statistics Report 2021

3.3.2. Participation in the Cabinet and other central level positions

Women's representation in the cabinet and other central level positions has increased from 50% to 55% for Ministers, 30% to 33.3% for Permanent Secretaries, and 24.5% to 32.7% for Directors of units (see Table 38). On the other side, a decline in women's representation is observed in positions of Director Generals (from 34.4% to 32.1%).

Table 38: Participation in the Cabinet and other central level positions

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Cabinet Ministerial Positions	50.0	50.0	45.0	55.0
Permanent Secretaries	70.0	30.0	66.7	33.3
Director General in the Ministries	65.6	34.4	67.9	32.1
Directors of Units	75.5	24.5	67.3	32.7

Source: NISR - National Gender Statistics Report, 2021

3.3.3. The Judiciary

The representation of women in the Judiciary system as captured by the three levels shows that, there is a positive progress from 42% to 43% for Judges in the Supreme Court. Table 39 shows that, the status for Inspectors in the Supreme Courts has declined by 50% and remained constant for the Judges in the High Courts (34%). Judges in High Courts remained unchanged over the last five years. In light of these figures presented in Table (37.) below, it appears that the decision making in the judiciary system in Rwanda is still hugely male dominated. However, it is yet to be confirmed whether a bigger number of women in the judicial system has a different impact in terms of access to justice by females. However indicative consultations with experts suggest that an increased representation of women in this sector encourages reporting of cases of GBV for instance, thus the improvement of response and curtailing this problem. Therefore, it is essential that men and women are equally represented in the judicial systems of Rwanda to minimize biases towards one sex or group of people but also to ensure that women and men are equally represented in positions of influence or decision-making.

Table 39: Distribution of judges and inspectors in the judiciary system (2017-2022)

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Judges in Supreme Court	58.0	42.0	57.0	43.0
Inspectors in Supreme Court	60.0	40.0	80.0	20.0
Judges in High Courts	66.0	34.0	66.0	34.0

Source: GMO, 2018; NEC, 2022

3.3.4. Participation in the decentralized government (Provinces and Districts)

As shown in Table 40, women's representation on the position of Governor of the province has remained the same over the last five years (40%). It has increased in positions of District Mayors (from 26.7% to 30%) and District Vice Mayors in charge of social affairs (from 66.7% to 78%). But this has slightly declined for the position of District Vice Mayors in charge of Economic Affairs (from 16.7% to 15%) and

for the District Executive Secretaries (from 10% to 8%). Despite some changes in terms of increased women's positions as District Mayors and District Vice Mayors in charge of social affairs, these findings suggest that the stereotypes persist about the capacity of women to occupy some positions, particularly those considered "hard seats". Consequently, at the district level, women still find themselves in so-called "soft positions", perpetuating therefore the biased beliefs that women are good at some responsibilities, in particular the social affairs, while they are not at others. For instance, women's representation as Vice-Mayor in charge of economic affairs has remained around 16.7% and 15% while the positions as Vice-Mayors in charge of social affairs, though high, is between 66.7% and 78% over the same period.

Table 40: Representation of men and women in decentralized local government

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Governors and Mayor of Kigali City	60.0	40.0	60.0	40.0
District Mayors	73.3	26.7	70.0	30.0
District Vice-Mayor in charge of Economic Affairs	83.3	16.7	85.0	15.0
District Vice Mayor in charge of Social Affairs	33.3	66.7	22.0	78.0
District Executive Secretaries	90.0	10.0	92.0	8.0

Source: GMO, 2018; NEC, 2022

Even though these statistics seem relatively static, the gains made can be expanded within the judicial system and accommodate more women in strategic positions where they can also aggressively push the gendering agenda while accommodating women sensitive issues such as reproductive health, access to productive and financial resources as well as influencing changes in mindsets at all levels.

3.3.5. Participation of women in the Media

It is being increasingly documented how media can play a role in gender transformation in every society. Their roles are to report on current events, provide frameworks for interpretation, mobilize citizens with regard to various issues, reproduce predominant culture and society, and educate. From the gender perspective, the media can be a key factor in the promotion of gender equality, both within the working environment and in the representation of women and men (in terms of fair gender portrayal and the use of neutral and non-gender specific language).

To date, the existing data point to huge imbalance in favour of men in terms of representation in the accredited media channels, houses and management positions. Clearly, the current media landscape in Rwanda encompasses a total of 310 media houses and is male dominant. Illustratively, Table 41 shows that, out of the total media houses in Rwanda, there are 28 female managers (10%) and 273 male managers (90%). Further, the media houses are classified into 4 categories:

- (1) The total number of radios in Rwanda stands at 34 (Out of these, 29 radios are managed by men, while 5 radios are managed by women).
- (2) There are 17 television stations in Rwanda (among them, 16 televisions are managed by men, and 1 television is managed by a woman).
- (3) The online media comprises 210 outlets (191 are run by men, and 19 are run by women).
- (4) There are 40 print media outlets (37 outlets are male-led, and 3 outlets are female-led).

Table 41: Participation of women in the media

Indicators	2023	
	Male	Female
Media houses (managers)	273	28
Radio (managers)	29	5
Television stations (managers)	16	1
Online media outlets	191	19
Print media outlets	37	3

Source: Rwanda Media Commission (RMC, 2023)

The predominance of men than women in the media poses some disadvantages especially when it comes to the coverage of very gender sensitive issues. It is well known that the coverage of any event by the media should be objective. Nonetheless, the presence of women on the radio, television, online, and in print is more likely to provide positive role models for women and girls, to gain the confidence of women as sources and interviewees, and to attract a female audience.

3.3.6. *Participation of women in the private sector*

The representation of women in the private sector is essential for them to earn from decent off-farm opportunities. This status explored women's representation in the governance of the private sector's executive committee at different levels: national level, the cluster, provincial level, and district level. We observed three positions, namely the president, the first, and the second vice president. Apart from the presidency level where the minimum constitutional quota is not achieved (30%), women's representation in other levels of PSF committee varies between 41.5% and 62.5% as depicted in Table 42 below.

Table 42: Distribution of elected men and women in the PSF committees

PSF's Executive Committee	Presidency		1 st Vice President		2 nd Vice President	
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
National	1			1	1	
Clusters	4	1	1	4	4	1
Province	4	1	4	1	0	5
District	27	3	19	11	11	19
Total	36	5	24	17	15	27
%	87.8	12.2	58.5	41.5	37.5	62.5

Source: GMO, 2018; NEC, 2022

The above status on gender equality in governance at all levels of leadership calls for improved strategies to increase women's participation in the decision-making at different levels of leadership. More specifically, future efforts will have to strengthen the existing mechanisms of mobilization and capacity building for women so as to optimize the opportunities offered by the existing high level political will to participate in leadership and governance including in managerial positions, especially at government decentralized entities, private sector and in the Media. In addition, there is a room to assess the possibility of legal and policy actions enforcing the representation of women in some of the positions usually occupied by men at different levels of governance using the "quota system". These actions will help to sustain the progress made and to ensure improved status in other levels of governance while expanding the system to youths in the process to support representation.

3.3.7. *Participation of women in decision-making at household level*

The policy and legal framework in Rwanda gives weight to the importance of power sharing and co-decision making at the household level. However, findings from different scholarly materials indicate a strong awareness of and accountability within these policies and laws supporting women's economic empowerment and decision-making, yet also persisting traditional norms or stereotypes of men as household heads and primary breadwinners (Stern, Heise and McLean, 2018). These norms, among others, underpin the sharing or decision-making as well as the intra-household bargaining power at household level between men and women (La Mattina, 2017). Inequality in decision-making at household level has some negative effects such as household-level conflicts, divorces, and inappropriate child care and nutrition, among other effects (La Mattina, 2017). The cumulative effects of these challenges have sustained strained relations at household level while also cascading to the community level through the “*extended family trees*”, thus greatly compromising transformation processes.

Box 2: Decision making and Conflicts at household level

Decision making at household level: The decision-making process at household level can be reflected at three areas: initiate the action or subject for decision, joint or individual implementation of the decision, management of the decision. Views from women respondents suggest that men and women who are legally married and living peacefully without conflicts decide jointly with regard to the use of assets. However, other respondents assert that men are dominantly initiators of the action or subject for decision especially on acquisition of financial loan, heavy investment in purchase or selling of assets such as land, livestock, construction of a house, TV and Radio devices owned by the household. While men focus on the above types of assets, women focus mainly on the purchase of groceries or clothes, health insurance, school fees, the purchase of small stocks, and other home related consumption items. The gap is also observed with regard to family planning. In urban areas men are more concerned by family planning and induce women to plan for the sake of reducing the number of births and hence the burden for child care. On the other side, men respondents argue mostly for a joint decision when it comes to the use of family income, investment in various household assets and family planning especially for educated people living in urban area. Further, the stand of the youth is their limited involvement by parents in decision making as well presence of some boys and girls who do not engage with their parents especially in formation of their families.

Household level conflicts. Part of explanation of the current trend of conflicts at household level and divorce is linked to the perception about the decision-making at household level which is still perceived seen differently among women, men, and the youth. A common trend is justified by prevailing conditions among of the spouses with respect to marriage regime, the level of education or literacy of married men and women, and competing roles and benefits on the use and management of the household assets. This is observed among legally married spouses and those living in informal union both in rural and urban areas. Further, in urban areas and among educated people, there are conflicts in “silent mode” or what respondents have named “smart conflicts” observed among the elite people and trying to mask the neighborhood and the surround society.

3.3.8. Gender Based Violence and Teenage Pregnancy

Teenage Pregnancy

The trends on *teenage pregnancy* have reduced when comparing the periods 2019 and 2023. For instance, as shown in Table 43 below, the percentage of women aged 15-19 who have had a live birth has reduced from 5.5% to 3.8%. Also, women who have begun child bearing has reduced from 7.3% to 5.2%.

By recognizing the positive efforts by the government to reduce teenage pregnancy, this remains a critical policy issue both from the health and justice perspective. Some of the reported trigger factors causing teenage pregnancy comprise poverty, family conflicts (these make children to separate from their parents and migrate to distant places), the need to meet some of the desired tangible daily needs such as telephone and clothes mainly driven by peer pressure, and limited adolescent education as influenced by social norms that makes it quasi taboo to discuss issues such as health education within homes and schools. It is also being observed teenage cases being associated with special and specific activities happening in the respective districts such as mining, tea plantation, and refugees' camps. Subsequently, there is need to have specific gender monitoring programmes or interventions in those specific areas to ensure that teenage pregnancy is monitored and effectively addressed at the lowest possible levels and structures.

Table 43: Teenage Pregnancy and Motherhood

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
Percentage of women age 15-19 who have had a live birth		5.5		3.8
Percentage of women age 15-19 who are pregnant with their first child.		1.8		1.4
Percentage of women age 15-19 who have begun childbearing		7.3		5.2
Had sexual intercourse before age 15 (women and men)	1.9	2.4	8.3	3.8
Number teenage pregnancies				

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

Gender-based Violence

GBV is a health and legal issue of international concern. Women and young girls are the most affected despite interventions by the government and partners to offset the trend. Both sexual and physical violence dimensions are the most GBV cases reported, they remain a challenge though a declining trend when compared the period 2019 and 2020. For women the cases of sexually related violence have reduced from 7,509 to 5,630 while for men these vary from 300 cases to 153 cases. Regarding physical violence, cases for women have reduced from 4,665 in 2019 to 3,508 in 2020. These are milestones that need to be up scaled and sustained.

GBV has multidimensional costs from the economic, social, health and legal perspectives. The immediate health consequences include marital rapes, sexual transmissible diseases and unwanted pregnancies including teenage pregnancy, among others. Further, GBV imposes the search for legal services for the victims and causes conflicts between affected families and the wider community fabric of friendship and relatives. Other studies have also started to estimate the costs of GBV on the economy including the case of Rwanda. For instance, the study by Spence (2020) has shown that GBV makes a small percentage of

GDP in Rwanda at 0.003% which primarily comprises victim costs, government costs to deal with GBV, and costs of the civil society organizations intervening in this particular area.

In addressing issues linked to GBV, the GoR and its strategic partners have established various enablers in this respect, while accommodating the social structures. The creation of Isange One Stop Centre in each district that supports the access to comprehensive GBV services (e.g., medical, legal, counselling and re-integration); presence of legal and institutional mechanisms to help GBV victims access needed legal services; availability of a government fund for reintegration of GBV victims; and community-led mechanisms in mobilization and structures for GBV prevention and response. These include Inshuti z'umuryango, Umugoroba w'imiryango, and GBV committee, and availability of safe places, shelters that provide protective options for GBV victims and those at risk of further exposure. In addition, the study by Burnet (2019) has identified three main factors that explain Rwanda's success in political response to the GBV front: 1) a well-established process for converting laws into practice; (2) the presence of professional technocratic corps at all levels of the government administration that operate within a strong system of accountability; and (3) the political will of ruling elites and power, buttressed by the ongoing support of CSOs. These factors, each of which directly reflects the dominant and increasingly institutionalized nature of its political settlement, have contributed to the broad and in-depth application of the GBV law, which has transformed the legal and institutional framework for victims of GBV. Table 44 shows the trends in incidences of reported GBV cases.

Table 44: Gender based violence victims

Indicators	CGSR 2019		CGSR 2023	
	Male	Female	Male	Female
GBV victims (women and men) with symptoms of sexual violence	300	7,509	153	5,630
GBV victims (women and men) with symptoms of physical violence	1,715	4,665	845	3,508
GBV victims (women and men) with symptoms of psychology violence				
Distribution of women and men aged 15-49 years old who have ever experienced sexual violence	5	22	5.6	22.5

Source: RDHS 2014/15 and 2019/2020

Cognizant of the progress as depicted above, some challenges persist and need to be collaboratively addressed. Key among these are: discriminatory and gender stereotypes around reporting of GBV related cases that limit access to justice by GBV victims; use of drugs, mainly alcohol; disputes/ conflicts around the management of family patrimony; limited access to productive resources, lack of sufficient evidences to support the prosecution and punishment of GBV related crimes; insufficient of skills and knowledge in handling and processing GBV cases; cultural norms, mindsets, and beliefs, limited community awareness on existing GBV related legal instruments and services, and consistent data collection in reporting GBV related cases, and limited effective re-integration of GBV victims hindered by limited resources. Consequently, there are also increasing cases of mental health related issues among GBV victims, mainly women, teenage pregnancy also resulting into high school dropout, increased family conflicts, and increased sexual transmitted infectors/ diseases mainly among GBV victims. These multiplier effects of GBV need more robust interventions that targets household and community level institutions while creating awareness about the costs of this menace.

To address issues linked to GBV, future interventions will need to focus on area of education of adolescent on sexual health as a way of preventing teenage pregnancies; more resources availed in re-integration of GBV victims in their respective schools, support long-term efforts to sensitize, train and support concerned practitioners (medical personnel, legal practitioners, psycho- social care workers) to provide safe and effective response to GBV victims; scaling up services of Isange One Stop centres to the health centres; and strengthen synergies among different actors on GBV cases to improve the accountability mechanisms. GBV victim friendly courts also need to be established across the country so as to protect the victims from stigmatisation post the remedial procedures.

Box 3: Silent gender-based violence for men

Both economic and physical violence have been identified among the respondents during the consultations. Causes include the polygamy and adultery (such as in Gicumbi and Karongi Districts), misuse of home resources such as land resources, use of alcohol and drugs, misinterpretation of the interventions targeting teen mothers for their recovery influencing teen pregnancy among others. In addition, some few voices were raised among men being also violated by their respective wives (especially those with financial capacity than men) but they tend to be silent and once reported it is not given equal treatment as for the case of a women-reported case. This needs more exploratory and explanatory work to document such cases to ensure equal and fair treatment of violence among men and women.

4. Gender Resilience to shocks: case of Covid-19

It is also important to document the impacts of potential shocks on gender equality trajectories across the different sub-sectors, as a way of identifying resilience nodes. These include climate change, conflicts, and existing and re-emerging pandemics. This particular section has documented the effects of Covid-19 pandemic on women's employment, businesses, income generation, and prevalence of GBV based on information collected from the case-studies conducted in Rwanda. In the following, we describe some of the indicative and specific gender related impacts of Covid-19 in terms of job losses, performance of women's businesses and generation income potential, gender-based violence, and unpaid care work. We use secondary data from government and development partners' reports as well as scholarly published studies so far conducted in Rwanda.

4.1. Impact of Covid-19 on women's employment

The assessment of Covid-19 impacts on women's employment was done through analysis of the data generated by NISR through its regular Labour Force Survey. For this purpose, we have considered data on employment collected during the period 2019-2022. Sectors and sub-sectors considered are those that are meant to employ majority of women while at the same time were too sensitive to Covid-19 related containment measures. These comprise (i) agriculture, fishing, and agro-forestry, (ii) manufacturing, (iii) whole and retail trade, (iv) accommodation and food service activities, and (v) Human health and social work activities. Figure 9 shows a positive change for agriculture (13%) and human health and social work activities (32.1%) but a negative change for manufacturing (-17.5%) and whole, retails trade, repair of motor vehicles, motorcycles (-3.0%) when compared the period 2019 (before the pandemic) and 2020 (during the pandemic). There is a drastic decline of employment rate during the period between 2020 and 2021 (a period post-Covid-19) and an increase of employment rate among women for women's dominated activities between 2021 and 2022.

Negative changes in terms of employment are observed in areas of accommodation and food service activities (-50.6%), whole, retails trade, repair of motor vehicles, motorcycles (-22.7%) and human health and social work activities (-10.6%). Some of the trends during 2021 and 2022 exhibit early effects of government's recovery measures in those specific sectors such as accommodation and food related services and whole, retails trade, repair of motor vehicles and motorcycles. Key among these is the targeted Economic Recovery Fund (ERF) to support the recovery of businesses hit by the COVID-19 pandemic. The two phase approach used by the GoR: where Phase 1 launched in 2020 was used as a mechanism to identify and support progressively recovering companies across sectors, while also accommodating women owned businesses; and Phase 2 launched in 2022 which provided funding to key sectors manufacturing that champion innovation, create employment opportunities and prioritize the "*Made in Rwanda*" mantra. Given that most women owned businesses are in the SMEs category, some of the benefits from this funds evaded these businesses while giving priority to large scale businesses in the process.

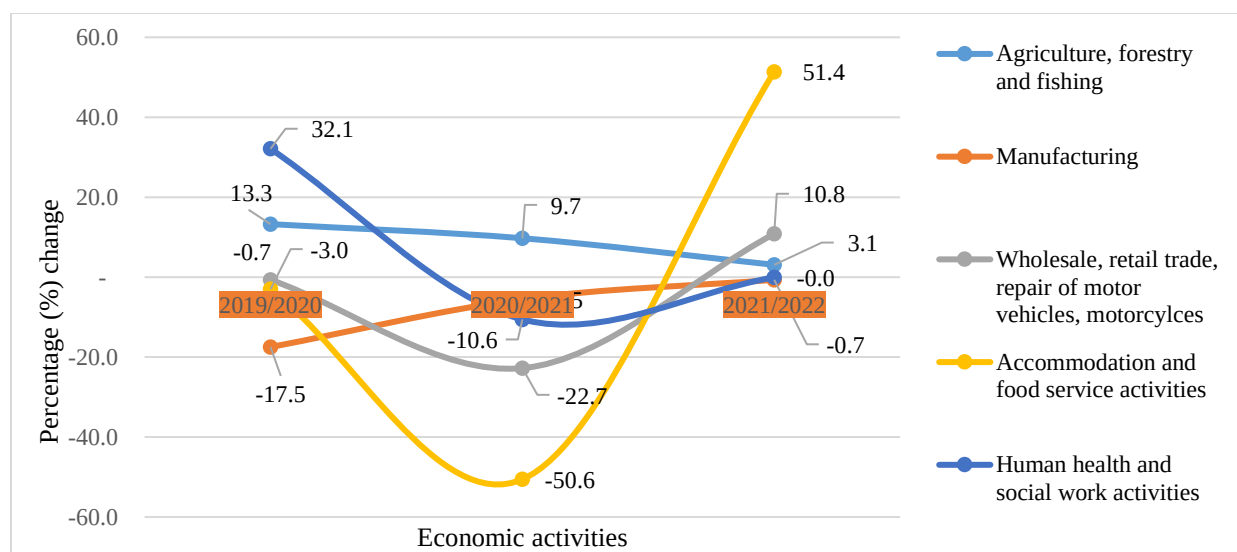


Figure 9: Percentage change of women's employment since the outbreak of the Covid-19

Source: NISR, Labor Force Survey (2019 and 2020)

4.2. Impact of Covid-19 on Women's businesses and income

Previous studies have well documented how women are majorly employed in the informal sector in Rwanda. Reference is also made to the status described above which depicts how women are more involved in trade especially in the cross-border trade. For instance, the number of women exporters in cross-border trade has declined by 76.6% (from 752,679 to 178,611 women exporters); a decline that is mainly attributed to Covid-19 pandemic.

Moreover, a rapid assessment study jointly conducted by the Ministry of Gender and Family Promotion, UN women, and the UNFPA (2020) has revealed how women were the most affected by Covid-19 in terms of their economic activities and income sources. The same report postulates that businesses operated by women have been the most affected compared to men due to Covid-19. It is stipulated that 54.6% of women have closed their businesses compared to 49% of their men counterparts. Likewise, women involved in informal cross-border trades were mostly affected by the pandemic than their men counterparts due to the lockdown travel restrictions.

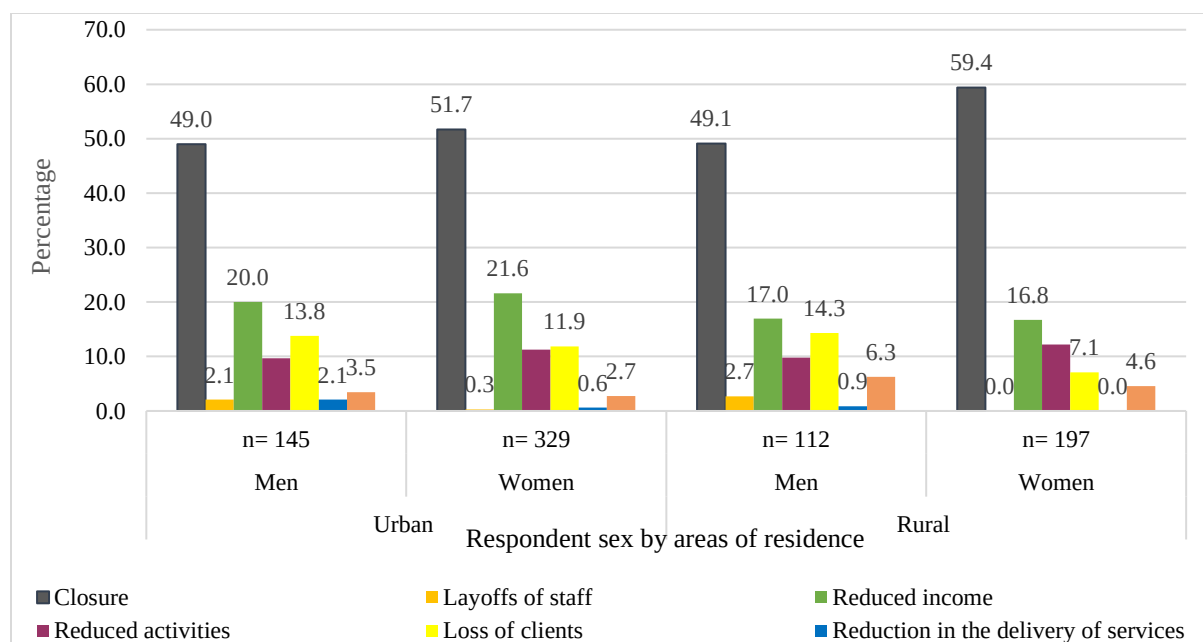


Figure 10: Effects of COVID-19 on business

Source: MIGEPROF, UN Women, and the UNFPA (2020)

As shown in Table 45, and based on the aforementioned disruptions, the monthly income for women has reduced by 69.3% and 67.8% respectively when compared the period before and during Covid-19. Consequently, this has resulted not only into income losses but also reduction in household consumption expenditures leading to other connected negative effects that could be transmitted to GBV incidences.

Table 45: Monthly income before and during Covid-19 among men and women using different posts of informal cross border trade (ICBT)

Variables	Before Covid-19		During Covid-19		% change
	Observation	Mean	Observation	Mean	
Estimated monthly income (disaggregated by ICBT posts)					
Poids lourds	140	150,229	142	45,542	-69.7
La corniche	8	138,125	8	53,500	-61.3
Rusizi I	26	149,039	24	49,792	-66.6
Rusizi II	17	71,588	15	24,400	-65.9
Bugarama	16	116,250	15	25,300	-78.2
Cyanika	8	126,250	7	63,857	-49.4
Estimated monthly income (disaggregated by gender)					
Male	51	201,373	52	64,865	-67.8
Female	164	120,909	159	37,167	-69.3
Estimated monthly income (disaggregated by value chains)					
Food	107	140,271	85	44,947	-68.0
Non-food	62	150,323	44	33,727	-77.6
Goods and services	21	107,619	17	45,941	-57.3

Source: MINICOM (2021)

4.3. Impact of Covid-19 on unpaid care work for women

Findings from the rapid assessment report (ibidem) shows how “*the burden of care and unpaid care work*” for women has generally increased since the onset of Covid-19. However, this burden has remained the same even in time of lockdown while the time devoted to most of home related activities has also increased due to presence of people in the home. On the other side, men’s time devoted to take care of the children has slightly increased during the lockdown. From the survey results, it is well indicated that women devoted much time in childcare related activities than men their counterparts. For instance, 71.4% of urban women confirmed that time allocated for instructing, teaching and training children increased since the onset of Covid-19 when compared to only 10.5% of urban men (see Table 46). This offers immense opportunities for home learning, thus reducing the burden for school fees requirements. However, gendering possible strategies to support this shift in investment and mentality will need to conduct deeper reflections on feasibility in different context where women and men need to rethink the tasks allocation processes and intermittently switch roles.

The pattern described above should be interpreted as circumstantial rather than a constant one. It is, therefore, recommended to strengthen the mobilization of men and boys in participation of certain roles with continued education on gender concept at all levels of the society in line with the on-going “Men engage” national programmes and initiatives.

Table 46: Changes (increased or decreased) in time devoted to the following activities since the onset of Covid-19 (for urban and rural residents)

Variables and response options	Urban				Rural			
	Men		Women		Men		Women	
	Increased	Decreased	Increased	Decreased	Increased	Decreased	Increased	Decreased
Cleaning (e.g., clothes, household)	17.1	9.8	43.6	10.7	28.3	23.9	43.7	12.3
Shopping for own household/ family members	12.8	28.2	51.0	254.0	17.8	42.2	10.0	57.5
Collecting water/firewood/fuel	18.4	5.3	33.0	11.8	28.6	8.6	33.0	12.7
Minding children while doing other tasks (e.g. paid work)	14.8	0.0	57.2	8.3	9.5	4.8	56.2	7.1
Playing with, talking to and reading to children	9.5	0.0	59.2	11.3	6.7	6.7	54.5	9.8
Instructing, teaching, training children	10.5	10.5	71.4	7.0	14.3	0.0	63.8	8.8
Caring for children, including feeding, cleaning, physical care	11.1	5.6	60.3	15.7	15.4	0.0	58.1	17.0

Source: MIGEPROF, UN women, and the UNFPA (2020)

4.4. Impact of Covid-19 on GBV prevalence

Different forms of gender-based violence were reported to have increased as result of the Covid-19 related restrictions and lockdowns. The same report by MIGEPROF, UN Women and UNFPA (2020) has reiterated more concerns to have been raised about the increase of GBV cases mainly linked to domestic and sexual violence. Results from the same report are more of perceived opinion. When asked on whether Covid-19 has caused increase of GBV cases, 30.4% of women and 18.8% of men have reported GBV cases to have increased in their respective communities. The spouse/ partner and neighbors were reported to be the primary perpetrators or offenders in the case of GBV incidences. This is consistent with secondary data collected from Rwanda Investigation Bureau (RIB) where GBV cases have increased from 854 in March 2020 to 1,243 in June, 2020 (see Figure 11).

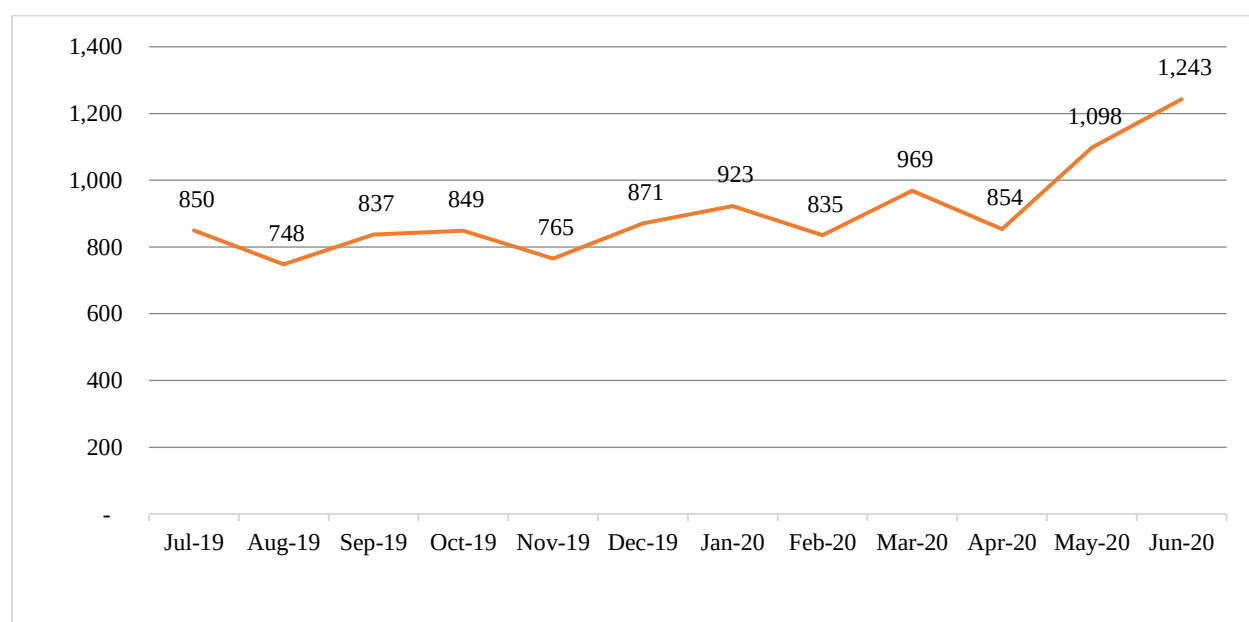


Figure 11: Trends of GBV cases (July 2019- June, 2020)

Source: RIB (2020)

Of concern is also the high number of school going children who fell pregnant, started out of school income generating projects and never returned to school as well as employees who identified other opportunities to sustain livelihoods and never returned to formal employment. All these also need to be traced from a gender lens as a way of understanding the holistic dynamics of the impacts of GBV and related issues as mentioned above.

5. Policy and Programmatic Actions

Gender equality, equity, and empowerment of women are essential considerations for national socioeconomic transformation in Rwanda. Interventions have been made at different fronts and significant progress and impacts are observed in many areas over the years. In the same logic, extra efforts are needed to improve the policy environment, the planning and budgeting of gender responsive interventions, the accountability, monitoring, and reporting by the various actors concerned, and among others.

4.5. Policy level actions

Informed by the findings from this GCSR, the following policy actions are proposed to leverage and improve the progress made in gender equality and equity on the way to sustainable transformation in Rwanda. Actions proposed are clustered under four areas: policy and strategic actions (PS), actions linked to planning and budgeting (PB) of gender responsive investments, and actions to improve gender monitoring, learning, and evaluation (MEL); and specific sector level recommendations where the gaps persist (ECT- economic transformation, ST-social transformation, and TG- transformational governance).

Recommendation #1: this status report plus other referenced studies have supported the notion of improved policy environment resulting from a high political will to integrate gender responsive actions in the overall policy planning and sector specific gender mainstreaming strategies. Actions are needed to position gender beyond being a “social” or “women” issue but rather integrating a shift to formulation of gender transformative strategies that can also be specifically translated into planning and budgeting tools.

Recommendation #2: there is a good progress of considering gender as a cross-cutting area in the sector strategic planning. While this has yielded some positive impacts, the approach also remains with some challenges such as unclear programming of gender specific interventions for some sectors. Proposed action is to identify gender sector specific issues so as they are integrated in the sector planning and programming. This will in turn facilitate effective gender responsive interventions, performance assessment, and gender accountability.

Recommendation #3: the GoR has initiated and implemented several planning and budgeting instruments. But there is little emphasis on gender responsive programmes to ensure that both men and women benefit equally along the various decent development components of designed interventions as indicated above. Consequently, the budget planning does not specifically show budget projections and the weight of resources directly allocated to gender related interventions in the sector-level budgets.

Recommendation #4: the monitoring and evaluation (M&E) frameworks of gender related interventions will need further review and adaptation in the current planning and strategic documents. GMO in collaboration with NISR shall organize a series of capacity development and coaching sessions and provide sufficient guidance on gender related data to be collected as well as adequate M&E frameworks for gender accountability. Similarly, GMO and its partners will need to define and decide on key and major sector level indicators to consider for regular monitoring and reporting on the country status of gender equality and equity in Rwanda. With this, the practice of CGSR development will be regular and consistent rather than being an adhoc process.

Recommendation # 5: the status evaluation has revealed encouraging progress but also shows some decline and underperformance in areas of women's economic empowerment. Good progress is observed in areas of access to improved inputs (seeds and fertilizers), employment, and reduced hours for unpaid care work. On the other side, persistently increasing gender gaps are observed in the areas of access to loan, land ownership, ownership of livestock and access to ICT devices and facilities. Clearly, comparing the period 2019 and 2023, areas that have declined are those meant to improve and sustain women's productive capacities; calling for specific interventions to ensure recovery from the initial status and continue to improve it. Areas of further intervention include:

- Increase women access to productive resources and climate smart agricultural practices including improved seeds;
- Develop innovative agricultural financial products, agricultural insurance, and other de-risking activities;
- Promote efficient land use by women through agricultural modernization;
- Create more formal and decent jobs for women;
- Use of more gender responsive and time saving facilities to reduce unpaid care work and;
- Facilitate affordable gender friendly and inclusive ICT infrastructure and devices, strengthen and scaling up of ICT facilities and infrastructure, while unlocking more partnerships between government, private service providers, schools, and communities to sensitize male and female students embrace ICT.

Recommendation # 6: in the area of social transformation, gender equality is more observed in access to pre-primary and secondary levels than it is in primary, TVET, and higher learning education. Programmatic interventions will need to focus on reducing the dropout rate in primary school and to ensure greater transition numbers of girls from lower secondary schools to upper secondary and higher learning education. Furthermore, more interventions can evolve around improved coordination of efforts from various actors in education sector including families, decentralized local entities and schools, and increase the number of students who are eligible for education grants from public and private actors to accelerate women's education in tertiary education.

Recommendation # 7: the health sector needs to leverage on progressive improvements in life expectancy indicators. However, more actions are needed to maintain such progress and momentum of transformation by assuring sustainability of access to health insurance, reduce the child mortality rate, reduce the incidences of GBV (both sexual and physical) and cases of teenage pregnancy. This needs to be capped by improving the nutritional status for both men and women as well as girls and boys.

Recommendation # 8: to achieve sustainable graduation out of poverty, a special focus on women will leverage on the current strategy for sustainable graduation by improving the service delivery and support to graduation. This demands promoting effective ways of working at all levels and triggering enablers to graduation by programme developers, implementers and services involved in facilitating graduation at all levels, and cross-cut all of the first four ingredients which means they are all required for each of these first four ingredients.

Recommendation # 9: it is clear that the distance to the nearest source of water is still higher for majority of households (55.6% for 200 m) and (40% for 500 m), the access to energy also remains a challenge for the majority of households (in a range of less 30 % for men and 20% for women). Future

interventions should focus on improving this status for both men and women with extra efforts for female by targeting investments in energy efficient cooking systems and community water points in the vicinity of most households. This has some implication on gender productivity especially the education of girl children who are mainly responsible for fetching water and cooking.

Recommendation # 10: women's representation in different positions at all levels remains with some gaps that can be plugged. It is proposed to strengthen the existing mechanisms of mobilization and capacity building for women so as to optimize the opportunities offered by the existing high level political will to participate in leadership and governance including in managerial positions, especially at government decentralized entities, private sector and in Media. Further efforts are needed at policy level to increase women representation in such positions. For example, an immediate review of the labor code, article 6 can be a good starting point. It is also imperative to extend the equality of opportunity at recruitment level and institutionalize role modeling and mentorship programme to build large and inclusive pool of women in politics and decision making. There is need to also assess the opportunity to advocate for parity law in political participation using the *quota system* targeting women. These actions will help to sustain the progress made and to ensure improved status in other levels of governance.

Recommendation # 11: to continue addressing the issues linked to GBV and move out of the abuse trap, it is recommended to intervene in the following areas:

- (1) Strengthen and accelerate the various interventions through synergies between the GoR and its partners in addressing all forms of GBV,
- (2) Education of adolescent on sexual health information as a way of preventing teenage pregnancies design and implement "second chance" education program for those who are unable to go back to formal schooling system as result of teenage pregnancy,
- (3) Embed GBV prevention and protection measures in the on-going Covid-19 recovery response plan and enforce the actions provided in different relevant policies,
- (4) Initiate country level campaigns engaging specifically men and the youth to break the silence against reporting of the incidence of any form of GBV in their respective communities,
- (5) Make more resources available in re-integration of GBV victims in their respective schools, support long-term efforts to sensitize, train and support concerned practitioners (medical personnel, legal practitioners, psycho- social care workers) to provide safe and effective response to GBV victims, and
- (6) Scale up services of Isange One Stop centres to the health centres; and strengthen synergies among different actors on reducing GBV cases.

4.6. Future priority areas or programmatic actions

Looking at the current progress that the country has made, future priority programmatic interventions to transform gender equality, equity, and women's economic empowerment are presented in this sub-section. These are preliminarily identified based on their potential multiplier effects in driving transformative changes in gender equality, equity, and women's economic empowerment:

- (1) Empower women and girls to access and penetrate the economic sectors/ activities with descent jobs and income.** These comprise the other components of the agriculture value chains (such as seed multiplication, agro-dealership, seed multiplication), service delivery and procurement, tourism, environment and climate change adaptation, mining, energy, among others.

- (2) Increase women's access to affordable drinking water and reliable sources of clean energy:** cognizant of the efforts made on water supply and energy facilities, access to these fundamental services remain a challenge and triggers gender gaps both in terms of unpaid care work and division of labour between men or boys and women or girls. The supply of water should go beyond the main source and ensure actual access of the quantity needed as well as the quality of drinking water. In addition, the energy sector shall continue designing strategies and interventions aimed at reducing high dependence of women on Biomass as the main source of fuel/energy by improving access to and use of alternative clean energy sources namely cooking gas and biogas in both urban and rural areas. Furthermore, improving women's capacity to adapt to climate change and variability will be enforced as part of future priorities to reduce their negative effects especially on women.
- (3) Bridge the gender divide in Tertiary, ICT, STEM and TVET education programs:** this status report documents a good progress in terms of gender equality in access to education both at primary and secondary schools. Major challenges remain in areas of tertiary education, ICT, STEM, and TVET education. Programmatic actions in these particular areas of education will focus on increasing female enrollment and completion in these programs, promoting competence-based gender responsive programs by increasing the female dividend in trades with more labor market potentials. The central concern will be to ensure that the training received by women and girls prepares them for the current and future entrepreneurship and employment opportunities, enables women and girls to benefits ICT related services and opportunities.
- (4) Adult education on gender equality, equity, and women's empowerment:** this status report has documented a positive shift on how gender equality, equity, and empowerment of women are perceived as result of previous campaign and community education programmes by the government with collaboration with civil society and faith-based organizations. This area of adult education bears a nature of continuous interventions in education of the adults on various dimensions or thematic areas calling for increased people's understanding of gender equality and equity as well as related benefits. These comprise adolescent education on sexual reproductive health, family planning among men and women, marriage and family constitutions, ethics and social and cultural values, dynamics of household-level decision making process, social norms and stereotypes that contribute to gaps in gender productivity, among other subject matters.
- (5) A new look at the legal framework:** It is now 28 years after Rwanda has committed to the 1995 Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (BDfA). Subsequently, a number of laws and legal instruments have been progressively put in place to support interventions related to GEWE pillars and outcomes in different venues such as the planning and budgeting process to ensure effective gender mainstreaming across sectors, matrimonial regimes, donation and successions, land access as well as the prevention and punishment of Gender-Based Violence criminalizes GBV offenses among others. But there remains a policy issue of a continuous rise of couples engaged in informal unions (with a current national estimate of 34% and above in some districts). The need to address this is already recognized at policy level (see for example the 8th strategic objective of the national policy on gender enacted by the government of Rwanda in 2021). The policy provides actions meant to guarantee a conducive legal framework that takes into account Rwanda's socio-cultural context especially focusing on property rights for women in informal unions. Interventions in this perspective help to protect women against matrimonial insecurity and guarantee equality and equity among the spouses in access and use of household level assets such as land.

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Annex 1: Cooperative Membership⁸

Cooperative Membership as at March, 2023					
Economic sector	No. of coops.	Membership			Share Capital
		Male	Female	Total	
Agriculture	4946	641026	503099	1144125	135,037,540,113
Trading	1568	95045	113705	208743	27,028,772,725,863
Service	1786	113607	100369	213,976	1,292,205,138,826
Handicraft	1056	22847	52789	75609	22,402,570,404
Transformation	196	14,662	9,885	24,547	284,574,480,108
Mining	140	58,380	46,846	105,226	1,311,390,900
Housing	170	19791	11676	31467	5561327038
Other sector	90	50,338	40,390	90,728	3,512,364,600
Primary coops	9,952	1,015,696	878,759	1,894,421	28,773,377,537,852
SACCOs	444	1,641,056	1,299,110	3,220,310	18,459,082,753
Unions	152	-	-	-	212,796,675
Federation	15	-	-	-	61,020,000
Grand Total	10,563	2,656,752	2,177,869	5,114,731	28,792,110,437,280

⁸ This is to be explored further.